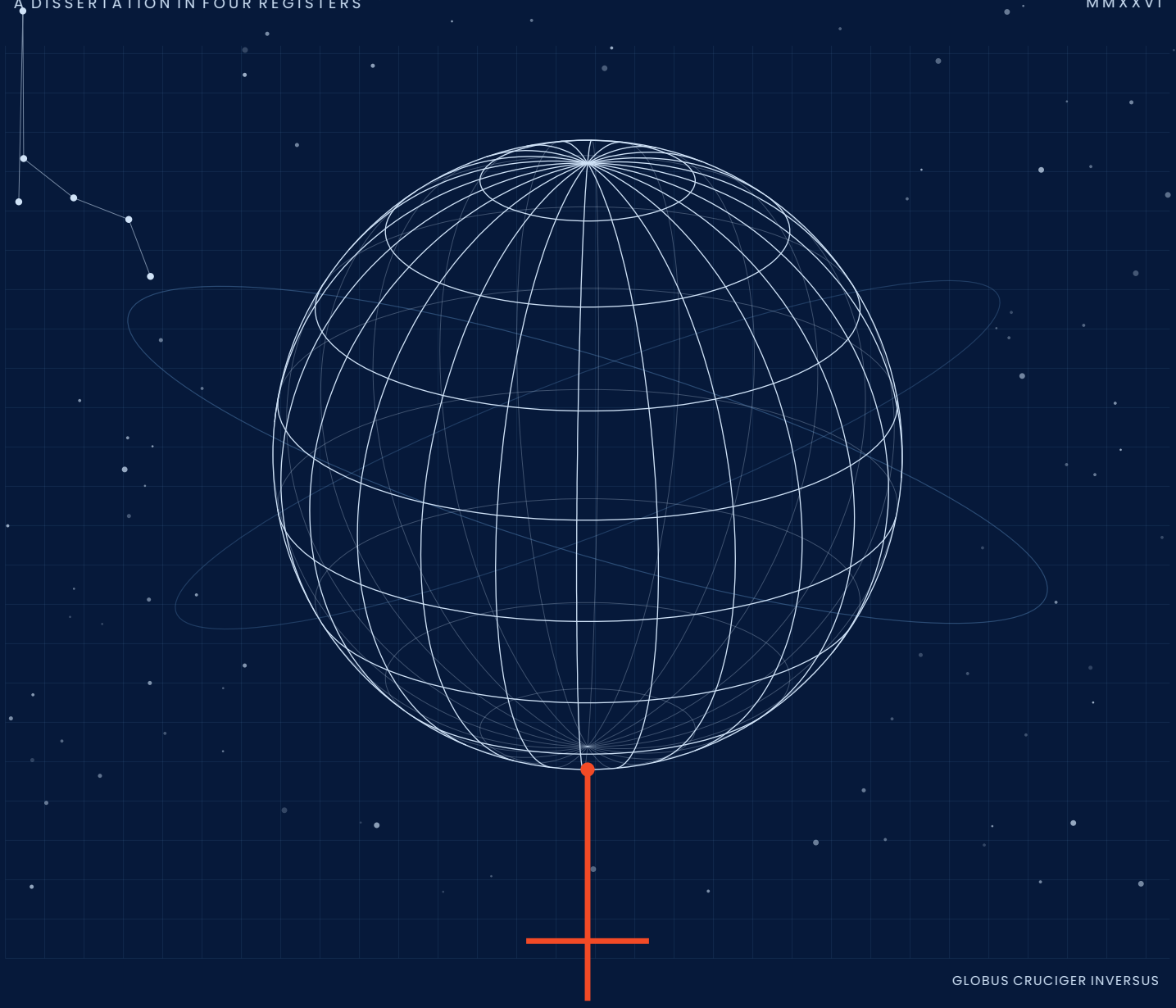
A DISSERTATION IN FOUR REGISTERS

MMXXVI



GLOBUS CRUCIGER INVERSUS

FERO, ERGO SUM.

The Noble Lie, the Ruined Memory Palace, and the Stigmatophoric Self in Yasumi Matsuno's *Vagrant Story*

AUGUSTINE · CONFESSIONES I.7.12

quam me vixisse non memini,
de qua aliis credidi

which I do not remember having lived,
concerning which I have believed others

CONTENTS

ABSTRACT 4

NOTE ON METHOD, SOURCES, AND TERMINOLOGY 6

INTRODUCTION 9

The Riskbreaker's Question

I THE MNEMOPOLITICAL TRIPTYCH 15

Matsuno's Falsified Pasts and the Square Cycle of the Counterfeit Self

II THE FORENSIC PERSON WITHOUT A PAST 21

Personal Identity after the Implant

III THE GUARDIAN'S DREAM 28

Noble Lie, Katabasis, and Recollection Inverted

IV HYLOMNESIS 36

Leá Monde as a Ruined Memory Palace

V MNEMONIC SOVEREIGNTY 44

The Blood-Sin and the Politics of the Past

VI LUDIC FORM 53

A Game That Remembers in Its Hands

VII A COMPARATIVE TYPOLOGY OF THE IMPLANTED PAST 61

VIII *FERO, ERGO SUM* 69

A Theory of Stigmatophoric Identity

CONCLUSION 76

The Ones Who Walk Away from Leá Monde

GLOSSARY OF COINED TERMS 80

BIBLIOGRAPHY 81

KEYWORDS 85

ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that Yasumi Matsuno's *Vagrant Story* (Square, 2000) is the most rigorous philosophical treatment of the fabricated self produced by the Japanese role-playing game of the PlayStation era, and that its rigour consists in a refusal: having exposed its protagonist's memories as a forgery of state, it declines to restore a truer past in their place. Ashley Riot, a Risk-breaker of the Valendia Knights of the Peace, remembers a wife and son murdered by brigands; the ruined city of Leá Monde returns to him the counter-memory that they were an innocent family he himself killed in error, and that his employers converted his guilt into the grief that animates his loyalty. The present study reconstructs this plot as a philosophical argument conducted in four registers. First, at the level of the person, it identifies Ashley's past as *heterographic memory* — a past written by another — and, more precisely, as *chiastic memory*: a recollection causally descended from an event whose agentive structure it inverts, so that the killer remembers himself as the bereaved. Read against Locke, Butler, Reid, Parfit, and Ricoeur, and against the Platonic *gennaion pseudos* or "noble lie," the game emerges as a *Republic* narrated from inside the guardian's dream. Second, at the level of place, it reads Leá Monde — a city whose earthquake-crushed dead are reanimated by "the Dark," and whose carved walls are revealed to constitute the Gran Grimoire — as a ruined *ars memoriae* in the tradition of Simonides, Quintilian, and Giordano Bruno, and names the Dark's operation *hylomnesis*: matter that remembers on behalf of a psyche that has been made to forget. Third, at the level of the polity, it argues that every faction in the game contends not for territory but for jurisdiction over the past, and formulates a principle of *mnemonic sovereignty* — sovereign is he who decides on the past — by reworking Schmitt, Weber, Kantorowicz, Foucault, and Agamben around the Blood-Sin, an inquisitorial penal brand that heretics transvalued into the key of a dynastic dignity. Fourth, at the level of form, it demonstrates that the game's mechanics — the absence of experience levels, weapons that accumulate affinity toward the kinds of creature they have killed, "Break Arts"

that exchange the wielder's life for force, a third-person camera that habitually renders the avatar from behind — enact rather than illustrate these theses, in dialogue with Bergson, Nietzsche, and Stiegler.

Situated in a comparative constellation that includes Philip K. Dick, Stanisław Lem, Jorge Luis Borges, Franz Kafka, Frank Herbert, Gene Wolfe, Ursula K. Le Guin, *Ghost in the Shell*, *Memento*, *Planescape: Torment*, and the *Metal Gear Solid* sequence, *Vagrant Story* is shown to occupy a singular position: where its peers restore, cast off, or tragically submit to an implanted past, Matsuno's protagonist *assumes* one. The dissertation's original contribution is a theory of *stigmatophoric identity*, compressed in the formula *fero, ergo sum* — I bear, therefore I am. The self is constituted neither by consciousness (*cogito*), nor by memory (*memini*), nor by narrative (*narro*), but by the free assumption of an inscription it did not author, cannot read, and cannot verify. The argument closes by reading Ashley's disappearance — recorded by the state as the murderer of a man he did not kill, carrying a power he declines to use — as a political form in its own right: vagrancy as the refusal of every institution that claims the right to write the past upon another's body.

FERO, ERGO SUM

NOTE ON METHOD, SOURCES, AND TERMINOLOGY

Primary text. The object of analysis is *Vagrant Story* as released in North America by Square Electronic Arts on 16 May 2000, collated where necessary with the Japanese original published by Square on 10 February 2000. The English script, localized by Alexander O. Smith, adopts an archaizing register redolent of the Elizabethan stage and the Authorized Version, which the plainer Japanese does not share. This is not a philological inconvenience but a first datum. The English text is itself an instance of the phenomenon the game narrates: it furnishes Valendia with a linguistic past — an early-modern English that no Valendian ever spoke — and thereby does to the fiction what the Valendia Knights of the Peace do to Ashley Riot. It implants a history. Wherever the argument depends on wording, it therefore rests on what the two versions share — proper names, the sequence of events, the architecture of revelation — rather than on the felicities of Smith's diction. By the conventions of this study, the game's dialogue and its prefatory verse are paraphrased, never quoted; direct quotation is reserved for texts in the public domain (Greek, Latin, Shakespeare, Locke, Nietzsche in the original German, and the like), translated where they are not in English.

Paratexts. The *Vagrant Story Ultimania* (DigiCube, 13 April 2000; 496 pp.; ISBN 4-925075-75-6; reissued 2006) contains staff interviews and a background narrative that closes several of the game's ellipses — most consequentially, the account, circulated in fan translations, that the Blood-Sin had joined the souls of Duke Bardorba and Sydney Losstarot, so that the death of either entailed the death of the other. This study treats the Ultimania as *deutero-canonical*: admissible, explicitly flagged wherever invoked, and never permitted to override the game's own withholding. The distinction is methodological rather than pedantic. The thesis concerns a subject whose past is supplied by an authority external to him; an interpretation that silently completed the game's silences from an official guidebook would reproduce, at the level of method, the very operation the game indicts. Development testimony — the team's published statements, the interview with Matsuno distributed at E3 2000, the composer's recollections — is cited through the sources listed at the end of the Bibliography.

Three grades of influence. Claims about sources are sorted into three strata, and the reader is asked to hold each to its own standard of proof.

1 *Attested* influences are those documented by the creators or indisputable in the text: the photographs of Saint-Émilion, in the Bordeaux wine country, that captivated the design team, the team's subsequent journey to France, and the five-person group formed in September 1998 to realize the setting; the development record's acknowledgement that the plot drew on Hollywood classics and blockbusters as well as on European and Asian cinema; Matsuno's instruction to the composer Hitoshi Sakimoto to abandon the brightness of *Final Fantasy Tactics* for something deeper and heavier, and to study the ambient scoring of *The X-Files*; the Shakespearean onomastics of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern, and Romeo; and Matsuno's long habit, visible in the titles *Ogre Battle*, *The March of the Black Queen*, and *Let Us Cling Together*, of borrowing names from the songbook of Queen.

2 *Intertextual* resonances are those plausibly available to a writer steeped in European material and religious culture but nowhere documented: the eighteenth-century French *Grand Grimoire*; the Old English *rood* and the inverted Petrine cross behind the "Rood Inverse"; the iron maiden; the Latin *iocus*, "jest," personified by Horace as a companion of laughing Venus (*Odes* 1.2.33–34: *Erycina ridens, / quam Iocus circum volat et Cupido*), behind the Church of St. Iocus; the French *le monde* audible in Leá Monde; Chaldea, antiquity's byword for astrology and magic, audible in Kildea; and the Bordelais echoes of Bordeaux in Bardorba and of Merlot in Merlose. These are offered as illuminations of the text, not as claims about intention.

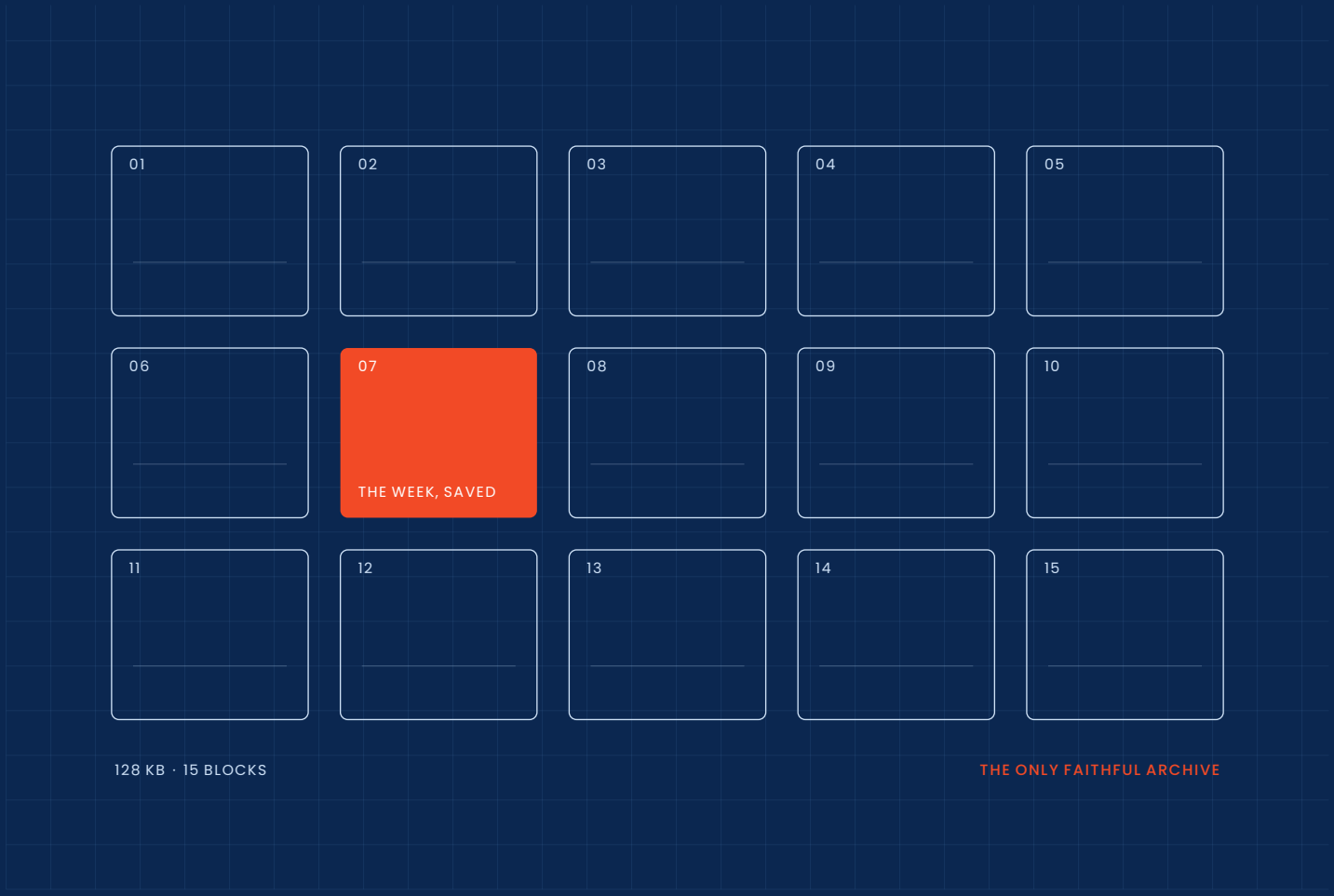
3 *Genealogical-conceptual* affinities are the philosophical traditions — Platonic, Augustinian, Lockean, Nietzschean, Freudian, Benjaminian, Foucauldian, Ricoeurian, Agambenian — deployed here as instruments of reading. No claim is made that Matsuno read any of them. The procedure is what Walter Benjamin called constellation: *Die Ideen verhalten sich zu den Dingen wie die Sternbilder zu den Sternen* — ideas stand to things as constellations to stars (Benjamin 1928, "Epistemo-Critical Prologue"). A constellation asserts no causal lineage among its points; it asserts only that, read together, they make visible a figure that none of them makes alone.

Methods. Four procedures are combined. The first is philosophical formalism: the fiction is treated as a thought experiment possessing the rigour of an argument, in the manner in which Locke's prince and cobbler or Parfit's teletransporter are treated in the literature on personal identity. The second is Ian Bogost's procedural rhetoric (2007), according to which rules and mechanics advance claims not reducible to the narrative they accompany. The third is Henry Jenkins's account of game design as narrative architecture (2004), in which space itself carries story. The fourth is Espen Aarseth's theory of ergodic textuality (1997), for which the nontrivial labour

of traversal belongs to the meaning of a text. Benjamin's constellation governs their combination.

Conventions. Proper names follow the English release: Leá Monde, the Dark, the Blood-Sin, the Rood Inverse, the Great Cathedral, the Valendia Knights of the Peace (VKP). Classical texts are cited by their standard divisions (Stephanus pages for Plato, book and chapter for Augustine, act and scene for Shakespeare); modern works by author and year, keyed to the Bibliography. The discussion presupposes knowledge of the entire plot, including the epilogue. Terms coined in this dissertation are italicized at first use and defined in the Glossary; the principal ones are *heterographic memory*, *chiastic memory*, *anamnesis without origin*, *hylomnesis*, *mnemonic sovereignty*, *dorsal legibility*, *spectral forgiveness*, *custodial inoperativity*, and *stigmatophoric identity*.

State of criticism. The interpretive archive surrounding *Vagrant Story* remains predominantly journalistic and fan-exegetical, much of it devoted to reconstructing lore from the Ultimania. As far as this study has been able to determine, no sustained philosophical treatment of the work exists. The present dissertation proposes one.



INTRODUCTION

THE RISKBREAKER'S QUESTION

X

X · CHI, THE LETTER OF THE CROSSING — CHIASMUS

1 A protagonist misremembered twice
2 The question
3 The millennial horizon
4 The Phantom Pain
5 Thesis
6 Architecture of the argument

1

A protagonist misremembered twice

Vagrant Story is framed by a single accusation, announced at its threshold and ratified in its epilogue: that Ashley Riot, Riskbreaker of the Valendia Knights of the Peace, murdered Duke Bardorba. Between the frame's two edges the game discloses the week that preceded the Duke's death and thereby exposes the accusation as false. Sydney Losstarot, wearing Ashley's likeness, is admitted to the dying Duke's chamber; the Duke kills him and soon dies of causes the game leaves unexplained; and a report received by the VKP a week after the Graylands Incident names Ashley prime suspect in a murder he did not commit. He is never found. At the centre of this frame lies the game's decisive revelation, which inverts the frame's error. Years earlier, as an assassin and saboteur in an elite squad, Ashley did kill: he murdered an innocent woman and child, mistaking them for his target, and the VKP converted his guilt into patriotic zeal by allowing — or causing — him to remember the dead as his own wife and son, slain by brigands.

The structure is a chiasmus, and it is the game's argument in miniature. In the past, the institution subtracted a killing from Ashley's memory; in the present, it adds a killing to his record. He enters the story as a killer who believes himself a mourner and leaves it as an innocent whom the archive names a murderer. In neither direction does the institution's account of his agency coincide with the facts, and in neither direction can Ashley correct it. The only party that holds an accurate record of the intervening week stands outside the fiction altogether: the player, and the memory card on which the player's progress is saved.

2

The question

From this structure arises what this dissertation calls the Riskbreaker's question: *if the past that made me was written by another, and if unwriting it does not yield a truer past, what in me remains mine?* The question has venerable ancestors. Descartes's evil genius (*Meditationes*, I, 1641) threatens perception. Locke's concern that a thinking substance might have "represented to it, as done by itself, what it never did" (*Essay* II.xxvii.13) threatens memory. Russell's hypothesis that the world might have sprung into existence five minutes ago, complete with a population remembering a wholly unreal past (*The Analysis of Mind*, 1921, lecture IX), threatens the past as such. *Vagrant*

Story makes two modifications to this lineage, and both are decisive. It gives the deceiver a name, an institutional address, and a motive: the deceiver is the state, and its motive is loyalty. And it converts the sceptical question into a practical one. The issue is no longer whether I can know my past, but how I am to live with a past that I cannot know to have been mine.

The answer this dissertation attributes to the game, and then defends in its own name, is that what remains mine is what I bear.

3 The millennial horizon

The game appeared at a moment when the fallibility and manipulability of memory had become a matter of public contest. The false-memory controversies of the 1990s — the founding of the False Memory Syndrome Foundation in 1992; Elizabeth Loftus and Jacqueline Pickrell's demonstration in 1995 that entire childhood episodes could be implanted by suggestion; Ian Hacking's diagnosis, in the same year, of a "memoro-politics" in which the sciences of memory became instruments of government — had made the recovered past a battleground. Pierre Nora's *Les Lieux de mémoire* (1984–1992) had described a modernity that commemorates obsessively because it no longer remembers spontaneously. In the year of the game's release Paul Ricoeur published *La Mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli*, with its taxonomy of blocked, manipulated, and commanded memory; and Christopher Nolan's *Memento*, premiered in September 2000, placed at the centre of the cinema a man who reads his past from the tattoos on his own body.

The Japanese horizon of reception was, if anything, more charged. The year 1995 had brought, within nine weeks, the Great Hanshin earthquake (17 January), which killed more than six thousand people, and the sarin attack on the Tokyo subway (20 March), in which members of the cult Aum Shinrikyō, on the orders of its leader, Asahara Shōkō, released a nerve agent on rush-hour trains, killing more than a dozen people and injuring thousands: a catastrophe of the earth and a catastrophe of the cult. Murakami Haruki's oral history of the attack's victims, *Andāguraundo* (1997), and his cycle of stories set in the earthquake's aftermath, *Kami no kodomotachi wa mina odoru* (2000), bracket the game's development. No claim is made here that these events informed Matsuno's writing; the record is silent on the point. But a narrative in which a state specialist in religious terrorism pursues a cult into a city destroyed by an earthquake twenty-five years before could not have been received in Japan in 2000 as a fantasy without a present. Nor, in a decade in which the historian Ienaga Saburō's lawsuits against the Ministry of Education came to their end — the ministry had pressed him to rewrite Japan's "aggression" in China as an "advance", contested his account of the Nanjing Massacre, and ordered the deletion of his passage on Unit 731, the Imperial Japanese Army unit that killed prisoners, most of them Chinese, in experiments on human beings, a deletion the Supreme

Court held unlawful in August 1997 — and in which the Japanese Society for History Textbook Reform was founded (1997) to campaign, among other aims, for removing from school textbooks the Imperial military's system of sexual slavery, whose victims are known as the comfort women, could a fiction concerning the authority of institutions over the remembered past be received as politically weightless. In both disputes the acts at issue were an army's, and what was being decided was whether a nation's schools would remember them — the operation the game stages inside a single soldier's memory.

The technical horizon rhymes with the cultural one. The PlayStation disposed of two megabytes of main memory; its memory card held 128 kilobytes, divided into fifteen blocks. The millennium itself arrived as a crisis of memory format — the fear that systems storing years in two digits would misremember the century. The development record states that memory was the most difficult constraint the team faced: interfaces, textures, and polygon meshes were pared back, and computer-controlled companions who would have fought beside Ashley were removed; more than half of the planned story was cut for reasons of capacity and time. The consequence can be stated with only slight exaggeration: *the Riskbreaker works alone because the machine could not remember anyone else.* Ashley's solitude is sublimated scarcity, and the game's notorious ellipses are the formal correlate of its hero's amnesia. It is a story that forgot half of itself.

4 The Phantom Pain

The plot bears a title, displayed on a title card as the narrative begins: *The Phantom Pain*. The narrator presents what follows as the prelude to the story of the wanderer — a story announced and never told. The title is exact. Phantom pain is pain felt in a limb that is no longer there; the phenomenon entered clinical description through Silas Weir Mitchell's studies of Civil War amputees in the 1870s, and Maurice Merleau-Ponty (1945) read the phantom limb as the body's refusal of its own mutilation, an ambiguous presence sustained by a practical world that still solicits the missing member. Ashley's grief is phantom pain in a double sense. It is pain referred to a family that was never his; and it occupies the place of a missing member of another kind — his own agency, amputated from his memory by the institution that employed it. The pain is real; its referent is phantom; its cause is real but displaced. Chapter II names this structure *chiastic memory*.

5

Thesis

The thesis of this dissertation is that *Vagrant Story* articulates, through the convergence of its narrative, its architecture, and its mechanics, a theory of selfhood that the history of philosophy has approached without formulating. It is here called *stigmatophoric identity* — from the Greek *stigma*, a mark pricked or burned into the skin, and *pherein*, to bear — and it is compressed in the formula *fero, ergo sum*: I bear, therefore I am. A stigmatophoric self constitutes itself by the free assumption of an inscription that it did not author (heteronomy of origin), cannot read by itself (*dorsal legibility*), and cannot verify (*anamnesis without origin*).

The Latin verb is chosen with care. *Ferre* means to carry, to endure, to suffer; but it also means to bring, to report, to hand on (*fertur*, "it is said"), and its Greek cognate *pherein* underlies *metaphora*, a carrying-across. To bear is at once to suffer a burden and to transmit it. The Blood-Sin, which passes in the game from bearer to bearer, is a metaphor in the etymological sense before it is one in the literary sense.

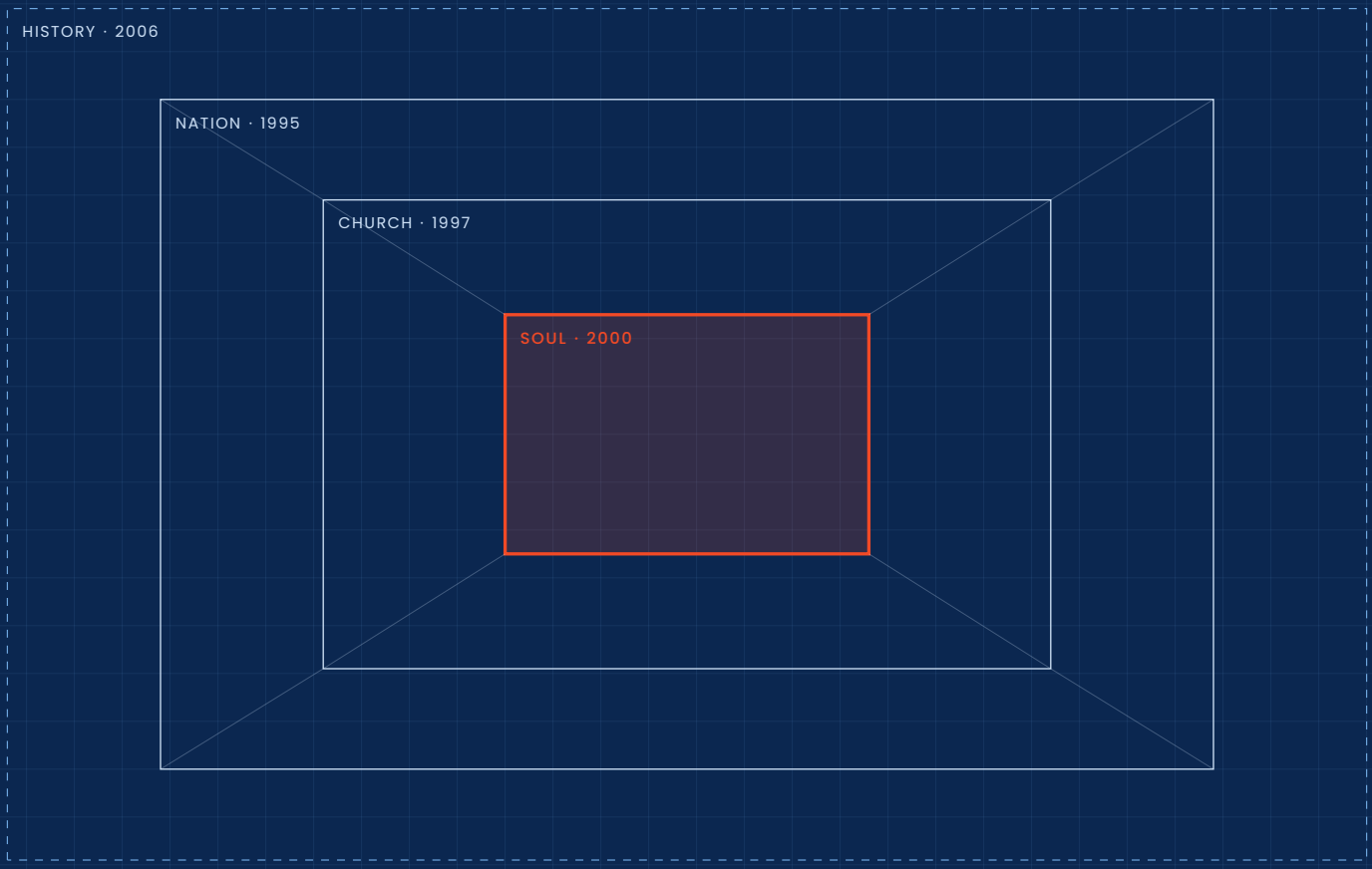
The formula is set against four rival principles of identity, each of which the game tests and finds wanting. *Cogito*, identity grounded in self-transparent thought, is embarrassed by a world in which a Heart-Seer reads what the thinker cannot read in himself. *Memini*, identity grounded in memory, collapses when memory is shown to be a forgery. *Narro*, identity grounded in narrative, fails where the story of the wanderer is never told. And existential self-creation fails because Ashley does not invent his past; he receives it, and then receives its refutation, and can author neither.

6

Architecture of the argument

The argument unfolds in four registers — person, place, polity, form — across eight chapters. Chapter I situates *Vagrant Story* within Matsuno's oeuvre, reading *Tactics Ogre* (1995), *Final Fantasy Tactics* (1997), and *Vagrant Story* as a mnemopolitical triptych in which the falsified past contracts from nation to church to soul, with *Final Fantasy XII* (2006) as an expansive coda; it then places the game within the contemporaneous Square cycle of the counterfeit self. Chapter II tests Ashley's case against the theory of personal identity from Locke to Ricoeur and defines chiastic memory. Chapter III reads the game as an inversion of the Platonic noble lie and of the Gnostic and Augustinian doctrines of recollection, and as a revision of *Hamlet*. Chapter IV turns to place and reads Leá Monde as a ruined memory palace, introducing *hylomnesis*. Chapter V formulates *mnemonic sovereignty*. Chapter VI demonstrates that the ludic system enacts these arguments rather than decorating them. Chapter VII constructs a comparative typology of speculative fictions of the implanted past. Chapter VIII formalizes the theory of stigmatophoric identity as a sequence of numbered theses and defends it

against objections. The Conclusion reads Ashley's disappearance through Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas."



CHAPTER ONE

THE MNEMOPOLITICAL TRIPTYCH

Matsuno's Falsified Pasts and the Square Cycle of the Counterfeit Self

I.1 Balmamusa: the massacre as a machine for making memory
I.2 The Durai Report: the church as author of history
I.3 *Vagrant Story*: the soul as archive
I.4 Coda: *Final Fantasy XII* and the sovereignty of the Undying
I.5 The Square cycle of the counterfeit self, 1997--2001

Vagrant Story is the third panel of a triptych in which Matsuno relocated a single political operation — the manufacture of a past that binds the living to a cause — from the scale of the nation (*Tactics Ogre*, 1995) to that of the church (*Final Fantasy Tactics*, 1997) and finally to that of the individual soul. Across the three works the operation is constant; what varies is the scale at which it is administered and the availability of a counter-archive that could expose it. *Vagrant Story* is the panel in which the counter-archive disappears.

I.1 Balmamusa: the massacre as a machine for making memory

Matsuno's career as a director began at Quest with *Ogre Battle: The March of the Black Queen* (1993) and *Tactics Ogre: Let Us Cling Together* (1995). The latter is set on the island of Valeria, divided among three peoples — the Bakram, the Galgastani, and the Walister — and it is widely read, and was reportedly conceived, as a meditation on the ethnic wars then unfolding in the former Yugoslavia. Its subtitle, taken from a Queen song, is a plea for solidarity; its plot is an anatomy of how solidarity is manufactured. The moral centre of the game is an episode at the Walister town of Balmamusa, a mining town of some five thousand people, held in near-servitude, who have declined to join the uprising. The Walister leader, Duke Ronwey, orders through the knight Leonar (Leonard in earlier translations) that the young protagonist Denam Pavel and his unit massacre the townspeople — Walister, their own people — and attribute the atrocity to the Galgastani, so that outrage will rally a hesitant population behind the uprising. The choice divides the game. Compliance sets Denam on the Law route: he carries out the massacre himself. Refusal, on the Chaos route, does not prevent it: Leonar's soldiers carry it out, Denam's childhood friend Vyce among them, and the massacre is then laid at the door of Denam, who refused it; he becomes a wanted man, an outlaw of his own cause. The Chaos route thus already contains the second half of the chiasmus that Matsuno would complete five years later: the record names as the butcher the one who would not kill.

Balmamusa is, in the terms of this dissertation, a machine for manufacturing memory. The deed is designed to be remembered falsely. Its purpose lies not in the deaths but in their misattribution, and its product is not a military advantage but a grievance: a communal past that will bind the survivors to the cause. The protagonist is placed in the position of perpetrator, the population in the position of mourner, the enemy in the position of killer. Five years later, *Vagrant Story* performs the same operation inside a single skull. The VKP takes a killing performed by its own agent, misattributes

it to brigands, and converts its victims into the agent's lost family, so that the resulting grief binds him to the state. *Vagrant Story* is Balmamusa internalized: the false-flag massacre has become a false-flag memory. And the Law/Chaos choice that *Tactics Ogre* offers to the player at the moment of the deed is withheld from Ashley altogether. It was made for him, years before the game begins, by an institution that then concealed that there had ever been a choice.

I.2 The Durai Report: the church as author of history

Final Fantasy Tactics, Matsuno's first work at Square and the founding text of Ivalice, lifts the operation from the ethnos to the church and the chronicle. Its frame is historiographical. The scholar Alazlam J. Durai re-examines the Durai Report, a suppressed account of the War of the Lions written by his ancestor Orran (Olan) Durai, which contradicts the official history: the war's hero was not the future king Delita Heiral, whose ascent the chronicles celebrate, but Ramza Beoulve, whom the Church of Glabados branded a heretic and struck from the record. Orran, the epilogue relates, was branded a heretic by the Church of Glabados and burned at the stake for his account: the church that had struck Ramza from the record executed the man who wrote him back into it. At the doctrinal level, the church's founding hagiography of Saint Ajora is contradicted by the apocryphal Germonik Scriptures, whose circulation the church labours to prevent; and its militant order, the Knights Templar under Vormav Tingel, pursues the Zodiac Stones and the resurrection of Ajora under cover of piety, its leaders possessed by the demonic Lucavi.

The continuities with *Vagrant Story* are specific. Vormav is Guildenstern's ancestor in type: the commander of a church militant whose piety coexists with a pursuit of forbidden power. The Cardinal who in *Vagrant Story* seeks immortality through the Dark has a predecessor in Cardinal Delacroix (Draclau in the original translation), likewise a prince of the church in the service of what the church anathematizes. Above all, *Final Fantasy Tactics* establishes the heretic as the bearer of a suppressed truth, and the brand of heresy — the designation that renders a person killable and his testimony void — as the church's primary instrument of mnemonic control. In *Vagrant Story* the brand survives, and survives literally: the Rood Inverse, carved into heretics during an Inquisition, which its bearers renamed the Blood-Sin. What *Tactics* treated as a verdict of exclusion, *Vagrant Story* shows as a mark that its bearers transformed into a key.

The difference in epistemic structure is no less decisive. In *Tactics Ogre* the truth of Balmamusa exists; the massacre happened, and the player witnessed it. In *Final Fantasy Tactics* the truth exists as a document that survives its author's execution and is read centuries later. In both, a counter-archive

preserves what the sovereign archive falsifies. *Vagrant Story* removes the counter-archive. There is no Durai Report of Ashley's life. There are only the Dark's visions and the testimony of two interested men.

I.3 *Vagrant Story*: the soul as archive

In the third panel the site of falsification contracts to a single psyche, and the contraction of scale is paid for with an intensification of the epistemic predicament. At the scale of a nation or a church, a falsification leaves traces in other minds and other documents; it can be contradicted by a survivor, a rival chronicle, a buried manuscript. At the scale of the soul, the falsified archive and the falsified subject are one entity. Ashley can check his memory only against his memory. This is why the only reliable record of the game's week lies outside the fiction, in the player's save file, which contradicts the VKP's final report with a fidelity no character can match. It is also why Akitoshi Kawazu, asked in 2007 about bringing Ashley into later Ivalice titles, could observe that the game itself reveals remarkably little about him. The paucity is not a deficiency of characterization. It is the character.

I.4 Coda: *Final Fantasy XII* and the sovereignty of the Undying

Final Fantasy XII (2006) was conceived under Matsuno's direction before his departure from the project in 2005 and completed by Hiroyuki Ito and Hiroshi Minagawa. It reuses the vocabulary of *Vagrant Story* — Riskbreaker, Leamonde, Kildea — and dilates the triptych's scale beyond the soul to history as such. Its hidden sovereigns are the Occuria, the Undying, who have steered the history of Ivalice by bestowing nethicite and legitimacy upon chosen kings. The renegade Occurian Venat allies itself with Doctor Cid and the imperial heir Vayne Solidor in order, as the game frames it, to return history to mortal hands; and the heroine Ashe, commissioned by the Occuria to wield their stone in vengeance, refuses and destroys the Sun-Cryst. Her refusal of the instrument that would make her sovereign over history rhymes with Ashley's final disposition, analysed in Chapter V: the bearing of a supreme power without its use. The onomastic proximity of Ashe and Ashley is noted without being pressed.

WORK (YEAR)	SCALE OF FALSIFICATION	AUTHOR OF THE FALSE PAST	INSTRUMENT	COUNTER-ARCHIVE	RESOLUTION
Tactics Ogre: Let Us Cling Together (1995)	Nation, ethnos	Duke Ronwey, through the knight Leonar	False-flag massacre at Balmamusa, blamed on the Galgastani	The player's witness; Denam's knowledge	Complicity (Law), or blame and outlawry (Chaos)
Final Fantasy Tactics (1997)	Church and chronicle	Church of Glabados	Hagiography of Saint Ajora; the brand of heresy	Germonik Scriptures; the Durai Report	Suppressed truth recovered by a later historian

WORK (YEAR)	SCALE OF FALSIFICATION	AUTHOR OF THE FALSE PAST	INSTRUMENT	COUNTER-ARCHIVE	RESOLUTION
Vagrant Story (2000)	Individual psyche	Valendia Knights of the Peace	Grief-memory of a murdered family	The Dark's visions; two interested testimonies; the player's save file	Assumption of an unverifiable past; vagrancy
Final Fantasy XII (2006)	History as such	The Occuria	Nethicite and designated kings	Venat's defection	Ashe refuses the stone; history returned to mortals

Read down its rows, the table shows a contraction followed by a dilation, and a single constant: in every panel the political community is constituted by an administered past, and in every panel the protagonist's decisive act concerns his relation to that past rather than to any enemy in the field.

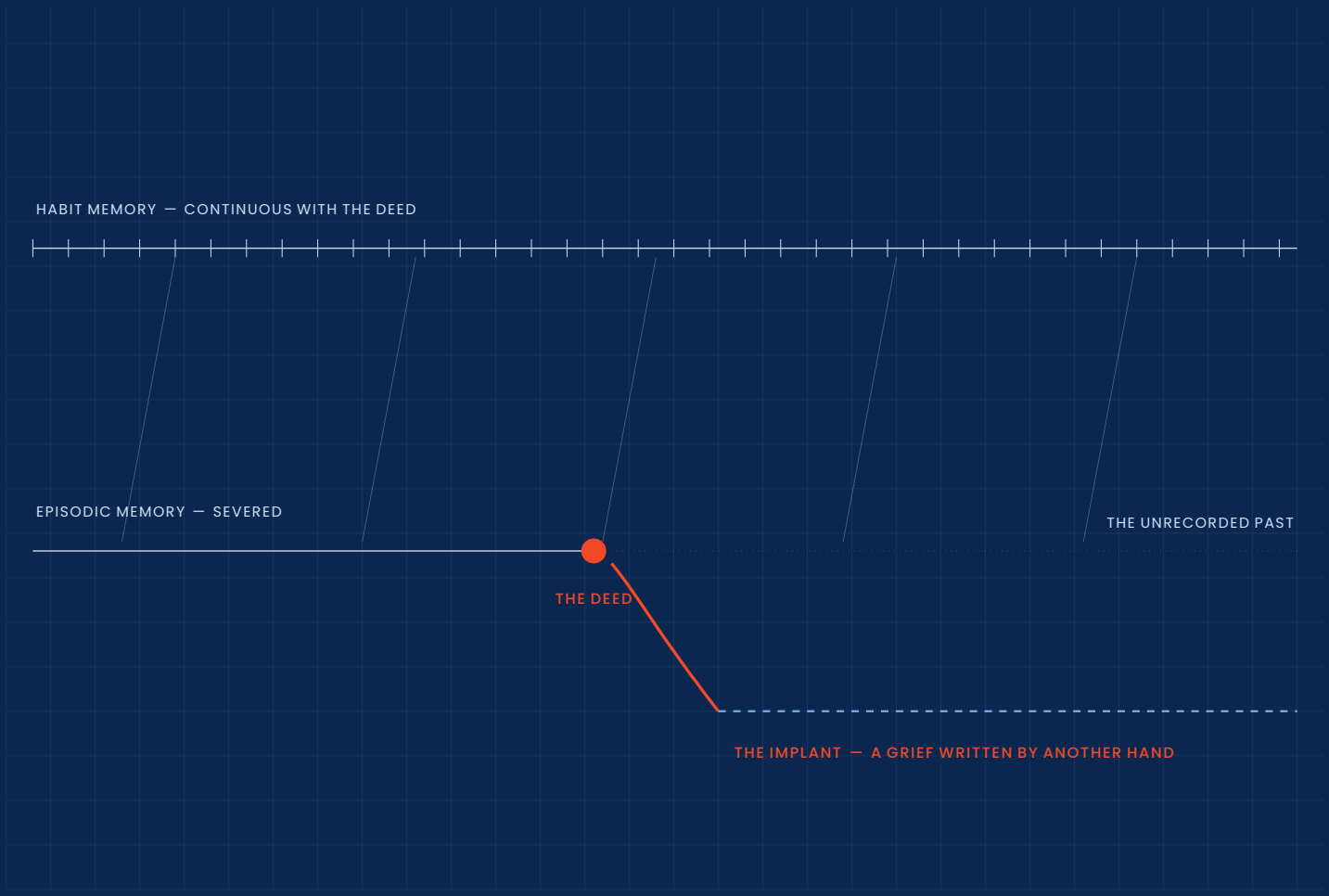
I.5 The Square cycle of the counterfeit self, 1997--2001

Vagrant Story also belongs to a second series, institutional rather than authorial: the extraordinary concentration, within Square's catalogue between 1997 and 2001, of protagonists whose identities are revealed to be counterfeit. In *Final Fantasy VII* (1997), Cloud Strife's persona as an elite soldier proves to be assembled from the memories of his friend Zack Fair, a confabulation produced by trauma, experimentation, and the mimetic cells of Jenova; it is dismantled and rebuilt within the Lifestream with the help of Tifa, the witness who knew him before. In *Xenogears* (1998), Fei Fong Wong harbours dissociated personalities, one of them, Id, murderous: at the game's outset, when his friend Timothy is killed in a battle between Gears over his adoptive village of Lahan, Id surfaces and Fei's Gear lays the village waste, killing Timothy's bride-to-be, Alice, among others, and the survivors drive Fei out. Amid an explicitly psychoanalytic and Nietzschean vocabulary, Fei confronts a hidden sovereign city called Solaris — a name that no reader of Lem can hear innocently. In *Chrono Cross* (1999), Serge's body is usurped by his enemy, and he traverses a parallel world in which he drowned as a child. In *Final Fantasy X* (2001), Tidus learns that he is the dream of the fayth, while the church of Yevon's teaching that Sin is humanity's atonement collapses into an institutional lie.

PROTAGONIST (WORK, YEAR)	NATURE OF THE COUNTERFEIT	AGENT OF REVELATION	RESOLUTION
Cloud Strife (*Final Fantasy VII*, 1997)	Identity assembled from a friend's memories after trauma and experimentation	Tifa, a witness from before, within the Lifestream	Restoration
Fei Fong Wong (*Xenogears*, 1998)	Dissociated personalities and a reincarnated past	Confrontation with his alters	Integration
Serge (*Chrono Cross*, 1999)	Usurped body; a parallel world in which he died as a child	Passage between worlds	Reconciliation
Ashley Riot (*Vagrant Story*, 2000)	Implanted grief for a family he killed	The Dark; Sydney; Rosencrantz	Assumption
Tidus (*Final Fantasy X*, 2001)	A being dreamed by the fayth	The fayth; the collapse of Yevon's doctrine	Dissolution

In every other member of the cycle the counterfeit self has a truth beside or beneath it: Cloud's pre-traumatic self, recoverable by a loving witness; Fei's integrated self, recoverable by therapy; the Serge of the other world; the dreamers who dream Tidus. The cycle consoles by three means — restoration, integration, dissolution — and each presupposes an origin: a real self to restore, a whole to integrate, a dreamer into whom the dream may dissolve.

Vagrant Story is the cycle's apophatic member. It negates the forgery without positing the original. Beneath the counterfeit Ashley there lies no true Ashley, only a crime; and the crime itself is attested by parties whose designs upon Ashley disqualify their testimony. The game consoles by none of the cycle's three means. It offers a fourth, which the remaining chapters theorize and which the Riskbreaker's question already implies: when neither the forged past nor its refutation can be verified, the self is constituted not by recovering its origin but by assuming its mark.



CHAPTER TWO

THE FORENSIC PERSON WITHOUT A PAST

Personal Identity after the Implant

II

II.1 Locke and the usurped guarantor
II.2 Butler's circle and Reid's inverted officer
II.3 Hume's theatre and the Dark's stage
II.4 Quasi-memory, Relation R, and the definition of chiastic memory
II.5 The memory wars: Tulving, Loftus, Hacking
II.6 Narrative identity, *ipse*, and the Episodic
II.7 Testimony and anamnesis without origin

Ashley Riot is a counterexample to every theory of personal identity that grounds the self in memory, and a test case for every theory that does not. This chapter argues that each classical account, confronted with a past written by another, fails at the precise point where it requires a guarantor — God in Locke, the right kind of cause in Parfit, a reality constraint in narrative theory — and that in each case *Vagrant Story* installs the state in the guarantor's place. The problem of identity thereby becomes a problem of sovereignty, and the chapter closes by defining the structure of Ashley's false past: *chiastic memory*.

II.1 Locke and the usurped guarantor

Locke's criterion is familiar: "as far as this consciousness can be extended backwards to any past action or thought, so far reaches the identity of that person" (*Essay* II.xxvii.9). Applied to Ashley, it yields a double absurdity. His consciousness does not extend backwards to the killing of the woman and child; by Locke's criterion, the man who walks into Leá Monde is not the person who killed them. His consciousness does extend backwards to the discovery of a murdered wife and son, a scene he never lived; by the same criterion, he is the person who suffered that loss — a person who never existed. The criterion absolves him of the past that occurred and assigns him a past that did not.

Locke saw the danger and deferred it. In §13 he concedes that one cannot demonstrate why a thinking substance might not have represented to it, as done by itself, what it never did; he answers that we must rely, until we understand thinking substances better, on the goodness of God, who "will not, by a fatal error of theirs, transfer from one to another that consciousness which draws reward or punishment with it." *Vagrant Story* is the case Locke bracketed: the fatal transfer, performed not by error but by design, and performed by an agency whose interest is not the just distribution of reward and punishment but the production of loyalty. The office of guarantor has been usurped. Where Locke's theory had God, Valendia has the Valendia Knights of the Peace.

Two further Lockean passages sharpen the diagnosis. In §22 Locke explains why human law punishes the drunkard for acts he cannot remember: his want of consciousness cannot be proved; but "in the great day, wherein the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open," no one will be made to answer for what he knows nothing of. *Vagrant Story* immanentizes the great day. In Leá Monde the Dark lays hearts open: Callo Merlose becomes a Heart-Seer and reads the hidden thoughts of her captor, and Ashley is shown visions

of his own past. Yet the secrets thus disclosed are secrets of the heart — beliefs, fears, loves — and not facts of the deed. The great day arrives and still cannot settle what happened. Finally, §26 defines the person as "a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit." The VKP is a forensic institution in exactly this sense. It appropriated to the state the actions of its assassin, so that his killings accrued to a justice that served the state alone; and at the game's close it appropriates to him an action he did not perform. The forensic person, in Valendia, is a ledger entry kept by power.

II.2 Butler's circle and Reid's inverted officer

Joseph Butler's objection to Locke is that "consciousness of personal identity presupposes, and therefore cannot constitute, personal identity" (1736, Dissertation I). The VKP's technique exploits the circle rather than escaping it. An implanted memory presents itself as the rememberer's own; in presupposing that it belongs to him, it installs the belonging it presupposes; and from that installed belonging loyalty follows as grief's natural expression. The circle Butler found vicious in theory is, in practice, a mechanism of capture.

Thomas Reid's brave officer (1785, Essay III, ch. 6) was flogged as a boy for robbing an orchard, took an enemy standard in his first campaign, and was later made a general; the general remembers the standard but not the flogging, so that by Locke's criterion the general both is and is not the boy. Ashley is Reid's officer inverted. He remembers a flogging he never received — a loss suffered — and has forgotten the standard he did take, a deed that is not glorious but criminal. And the failure of transitivity that in Reid results from the ordinary decay of memory results in Valendia from administration. Reid drew the moral that memory is evidence of identity rather than its ground. Ashley's case vindicates the evidential view and aggravates it: evidence can be manufactured, and when the only evidence of a self's past has been manufactured, the self must be secured on some other footing or not at all.

II.3 Hume's theatre and the Dark's stage

For Hume the mind is "a kind of theatre, where several perceptions successively make their appearance" (*Treatise* 1.4.6), but he at once withdraws the metaphor: "nor have we the most distant notion of the place, where these scenes are represented." Leá Monde supplies the place Hume denied. It is a literal theatre in which perceptions of the past are staged — the murdered family, the massacre, the brigands — by an agency that selects what is shown and when. The bundle theory, which dissolved the self into its perceptions, presupposed that no one arranges the bundle. *Vagrant Story* introduces a stage manager, and in fact two rival ones: the institution that

staged Ashley's grief, and the Dark that stages its refutation. Humean identity, which Hume called a fiction of the imagination, becomes in Valendia a fiction of the state.

II.4 Quasi-memory, Relation R, and the definition of chiastic memory

Sydney Shoemaker (1970) introduced *quasi-memory*: an apparent memory of an experience that someone had, causally derived from that experience in the right way, whether or not the rememberer is the one who had it; ordinary memory is quasi-memory plus identity. Derek Parfit (1971; 1984) generalized the point into Relation R, psychological connectedness and continuity, and argued that what matters in survival is R rather than identity; on the wide version of his view, R may hold by any cause.

Ashley's grief-memory is not a quasi-memory, because no one in the fiction is shown to have had the experience it presents — that of a husband and father finding his family slain. (Were there a surviving widower of the woman Ashley killed, the memory would acquire a monstrous precision: the killer would be quasi-remembering his victim's survivor's grief. The text is silent, and the possibility is noted only to show how far the structure can be pressed.) Nor is it a mere confabulation, for confabulations lack a specific causal origin in the event they misrepresent, whereas this representation is causally descended from a real event in which Ashley participated. It belongs to a fourth kind, which this dissertation calls *chiastic memory* and defines as follows. A representation *R* in a subject *S* is a chiastic memory of an event *E* if and only if:

1. *R* presents itself to *S* as *S*'s own experience of an event *E**;
2. *R* is causally descended from *E*, in which *S* participated;
3. *E** preserves the patient-structure of *E* — who suffered, and what was lost;
4. *E** inverts the agentive structure of *E*, relocating *S* from the position of agent to the position of patient or bereaved witness;
5. the inversion is functional: it converts the moral charge of *E* (guilt) into a motivational charge of opposite valence (grief, and the zeal grief licenses), which is then placed at the disposal of the party that performed the inversion.

The fifth clause distinguishes chiastic memory from the self-serving distortions studied in the psychology of perpetrators. A perpetrator who remembers himself as a victim distorts in his own interest. Ashley's memory distorts in the interest of another. It is *heterographic*: written by a hand not his own and for a purpose not his own.

The Parfitian consequences are instructive. Relation R holds between Ashley-now and Ashley-the-killer in one strand and fails in another. The

habit strand survives intact: the combat skills the Dark unseals in him are the skills with which the killing was done, and they are authentically his. The episodic strand is severed and counterfeited. What matters, on Parfit's view, survives in the hands and not in the heart; the body is continuous with the crime while the mind is continuous with a fiction. Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) anticipated the moral weight of this split, arguing that a person told that his memories will be exchanged and his body then tortured has reason to fear the pain. Williams's intuition, transposed, says that Ashley has reason to answer for what his body did, whatever his memory reports. The game will make exactly this answerability, rather than recollection, the foundation of Ashley's selfhood.

II.5 The memory wars: Tulving, Loftus, Hacking

Endel Tulving's distinction (1972) between episodic memory, of personally experienced events, and semantic memory, of facts, clarifies the craft of the implant. The VKP forged an episode in order to deliver a doctrine. Ashley's false memory has episodic form — a scene, a loss, a moment — and semantic function: it tells him who he is, whom he serves, and whom he must hate. The experimental literature had shown by the millennium how pliable such episodes are. Loftus and Palmer (1974) demonstrated that the verb in a question (*smashed* rather than *hit*) could inflate remembered speeds and produce recollections of broken glass that had never existed; Loftus and Pickrell (1995) implanted entire childhood episodes. Ian Hacking (1995) placed these findings in political context, arguing that the sciences of memory had constituted a third pole of modern power, a *memoro-politics*, beside the anatomo-politics of the individual body and the bio-politics of populations that Foucault had described.

Vagrant Story stages the recovered-memory scenario of the 1990s and inverts it twice. What Ashley recovers is not a memory of victimization but a memory of perpetration; and the recovery is not validated by a therapeutic authority but offered by interested parties amid the phantasmagoria of a haunted city. The game thereby refuses both camps of the memory wars. Against the partisans of recovered memory, it denies that recovery certifies truth. Against their sceptical opponents, it denies that the debunking of a false memory returns the subject to a verifiable baseline. The forgery is removed and nothing certain takes its place.

II.6 Narrative identity, *ipse*, and the Episodic

Alasdair MacIntyre (1981) conceived the unity of a human life as the unity of a narrative quest, a story of which the self is the subject and which is its own. Ashley's narrative is not his own; it was drafted by an institution, and the self it unifies is the institution's instrument. Marya Schechtman's narrative self-constitution view (1996) guards against such cases with a reality constraint: a self-constituting narrative must cohere with the basic facts. Ashley's narrative violated the reality constraint and was nonetheless constitutive — he lived by it, fought by it, and was loyal by it — which shows that where an institution controls the evidence, the reality constraint is administered by the institution.

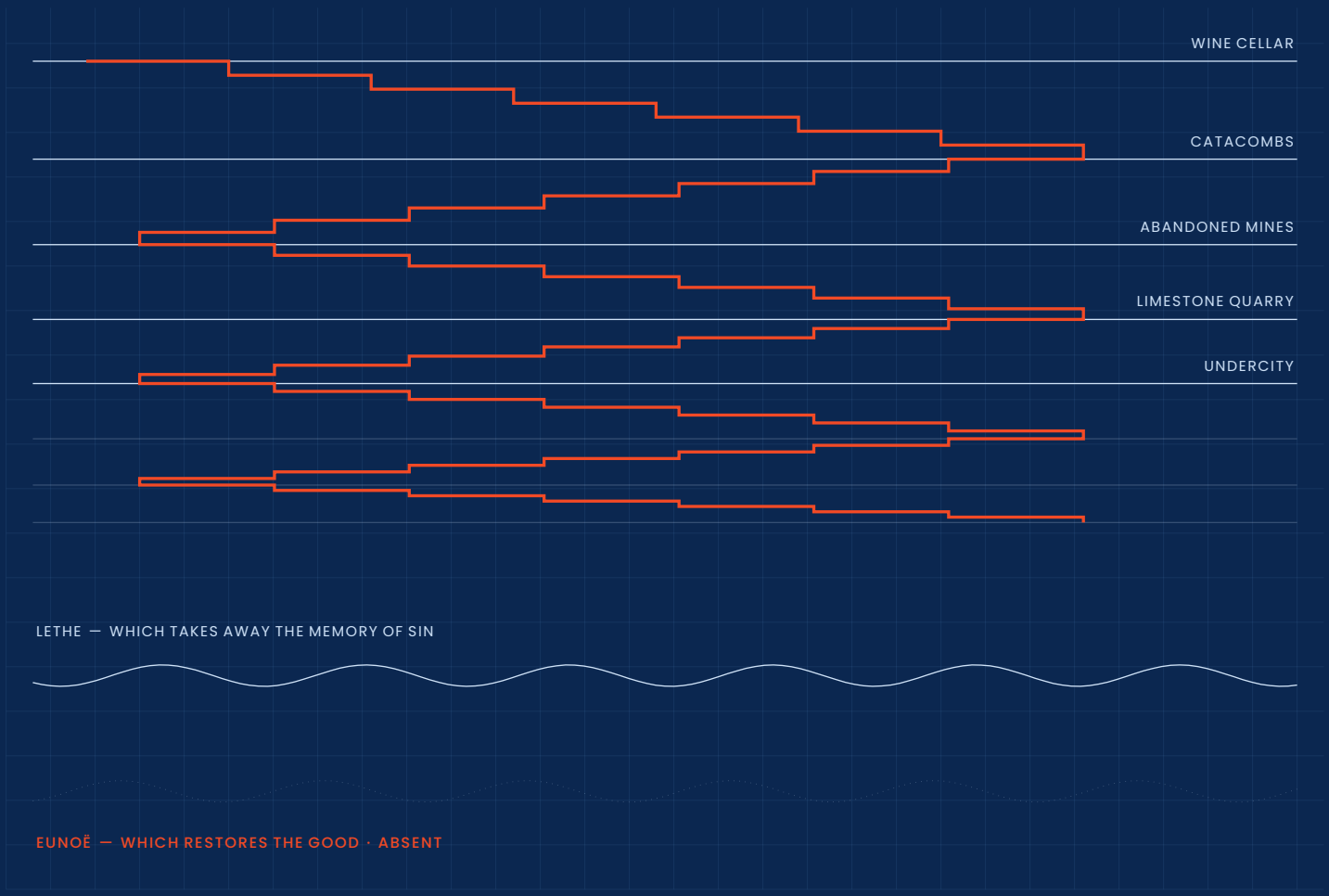
Paul Ricoeur's distinction (1990) between *idem*-identity, sameness of character over time, and *ipse*-identity, selfhood as self-constancy, offers the most promising resource. Ricoeur's paradigm of *ipse* is the kept promise: I remain myself not because I am unchanged but because I hold to my word despite change. Narrative identity, for Ricoeur, mediates between the two. *Vagrant Story* severs the mediation. After the game has destroyed Ashley's *idem* — his remembered sameness — it leaves him with an *ipse* unmediated by narrative: a fidelity without a remembered origin, a promise kept on behalf of a past he cannot recount. Galen Strawson's critique of narrativity (2004), which defends the Episodic temperament that does not experience its past as its own story, is illuminating by contrast. Ashley is not an Episodic by temperament; he is an Episodic by expropriation. And the game will not allow him the Episodic's freedom from the past, because the past has left a mark that persists without a story. The self the game arrives at is neither narrated nor episodic. It is carried.

II.7 Testimony and anamnesis without origin

C. A. J. Coady (1992) argued that testimony is a basic source of knowledge, irreducible to perception and inference, and that most of what anyone knows about the world, and much of what anyone knows about his own early life, rests upon the word of others. The revelation in *Vagrant Story* has the structure of testimony, and of compromised testimony. It is delivered by Sydney Losstarot, a cult leader who wishes to make Ashley his heir; by Jan Rosencrantz, a rival Riskbreaker who covets the same inheritance and claims to have been Ashley's partner in the killing; and by visions supplied by the Dark, a power known throughout the game to raise phantoms and animate the dead. Callo Merlose, whose doctorate in criminal and religious psychology makes her the fiction's professional of belief, states the epistemic problem outright: even if Sydney can see into the past, nothing guarantees that he reports what he sees truly.

The counter-memory is therefore no better warranted than the memory it replaces. This is the condition this dissertation calls *anamnesis without origin*: an unmasking that removes a forgery without delivering an original. Ashley's past becomes a disjunction he cannot resolve — either he killed an innocent family and his grief is the state's fabrication, or he is a bereaved husband whose grief Sydney has poisoned for purposes of his own, or the truth is neither. The phantoms of the family who appear to him at the climax, urging him to forget the past and become the man he wishes to be, do not resolve the disjunction. They release him from the demand to resolve it.

The classical theories of personal identity, confronted with this case, share a single failure. Each requires a guarantor of the link between present self and past — divine goodness, the appropriate cause, the constraint of reality — and each guarantor has, in Valendia, been occupied by power. The question of who I am becomes the question of who has the authority to decide what I did. That question is political, and it is answered in Chapter V. But its first answer is mythic, and it was given by Plato, to whom the next chapter turns.



CHAPTER THREE

THE GUARDIAN'S DREAM

Noble Lie, Katabasis, and Recollection Inverted

III

III.1 The noble lie, seen from within
III.2 Katabasis: the descent to one's own formation
III.3 Purgatory without Eunoë
III.4 The inverted Cave
III.5 The anti-Er
III.6 Gnostic anamnesis inverted
III.7 Augustine: the fields of memory and the sin of blood
III.8 The Grand Inquisitor and the heart-knower
III.9 *Hamlet*: the forged ghost and the sealed commission

Vagrant Story is the *Republic* narrated from inside the guardian's dream. This chapter reads the game against the principal Western myths of a falsified or forgotten origin — Plato's noble lie, the descent to the dead, the myth of Er, Gnostic and Augustinian recollection, Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, and *Hamlet* — and shows that it inverts each of them at the same point: where the myth promises that the descent or the awakening restores a true origin, the game delivers an origin that cannot be verified, and a self that must be built without one.

III.1 The noble lie, seen from within

In *Republic* III (414b–415d) Socrates proposes that the founders of the city persuade the guardians, and if possible the rulers themselves, of "one noble falsehood" (*gennaion ti hen pseudomenous*, 414b–c). The citizens are to be told that their upbringing and education were merely like dreams (*hōsper oneirata*, 414d), while in truth they were being moulded and nurtured beneath the earth, which, having formed them, sent them up as its children; that they must therefore defend the land as a mother and regard their fellow citizens as brothers born of the same soil; and that the god mixed gold into rulers, silver into auxiliaries, and iron and bronze into farmers and craftsmen. Karl Popper (1945) rendered the phrase "lordly lie" and read it as the charter of state propaganda.

The VKP's implant is a noble lie of an unprecedented kind. Plato's lie is public, collective, and foundational: told to all, it constitutes a class. The VKP's lie is private, bespoke, and operational: told to one man, it constitutes an instrument. Plato's guardians are told that their real life was a dream; Ashley is given a dream — the murdered family — and told that it was his real life. Yet the function is identical. The guardian must be what *Republic* II (375a–376c) calls a well-bred dog, gentle to those it knows and fierce to strangers, and therefore "philosophical" in the literal sense that it distinguishes friend from foe by knowledge alone (376a–b). The Riskbreaker is that dog. His ferocity toward the state's enemies is fuelled by the grief the lie supplied, and his knowledge of friend and foe is exactly what was forged.

The myth's most arresting detail becomes, in the game, a topography. The noble lie says that the guardians were formed *under the earth*. Ashley descends under the earth — through wine cellar, catacombs, mines, quarry, and undercity — in order to learn how he was formed. Plato's subterranean womb is literalized and inverted: what lies below is not the maternal soil but the crushed dead of an entire city, and what is learned there is not that the citizens are brothers but that the guardian is a murderer.

The *Republic* also supplies the political theory that Ashley's one comrade voices. Jan Rosencrantz tells him that the Riskbreakers were champions of justice, but of a justice that served the state alone. This is Thrasymachus's thesis (338c) that justice is "the advantage of the stronger" (*to tou kreittonos sympheron*), spoken not by a sophist in a drawing room but by a practitioner in the field, and spoken as disillusion rather than as provocation.

III.2 Katabasis: the descent to one's own formation

The *Republic* opens with a descent: *katebēn chthes eis Peiraia*, "I went down yesterday to the Piraeus" (327a). The first word announces the dialogue's ascent-and-descent structure and places it within the oldest pattern of Greek narrative, the *katabasis*, the descent to the dead from which the hero returns with knowledge unobtainable in the upper world — Odysseus's *nekyia* (*Odyssey* XI), Orpheus, Heracles, Aeneas. Ashley's penetration of Leá Monde is a *nekyia*. He consults the dead about the past, and the dead answer.

But the dead of Leá Monde are not the shades of the classical underworld. Romeo Guildenstern names their condition *incomplete death*: souls trapped in purgation, yearning for life, who seek bodies without souls and so produce the corpses that walk. The classical *nekyia* consulted the dead because they were past; Leá Monde's dead are the past refusing to be past. Virgil's underworld, by contrast, ends in oblivion: the souls destined for new bodies gather at the river Lethe, *securos latices et longa oblivia potant*, "they drink the waters that free from care, and long forgetting" (*Aeneid* VI.715). The Virgilian descent ends with the dead forgetting in order to return to life. Ashley's descent ends with the living forced to remember in order to become someone at all.

III.3 Purgatory without Eunoë

Guildenstern's theological vocabulary of purgation invites a Dantean reading, and the invitation is precise. At the summit of Dante's mountain of Purgatory, in the Earthly Paradise, a single spring divides into two rivers: Lethe, which removes the memory of sin, and Eunoë, which restores the memory of every good deed — *che toglie altrui memoria del peccato; / da l'altra d'ogne ben fatto la rende* (*Purgatorio* XXVIII.128–129). The purified soul, having forgotten its guilt and recovered its merit, is ready to ascend.

The structure of *Vagrant Story* is an ascent through a purgatorial city toward a cathedral at its summit, and at its climax Ashley is confronted by the phantoms of the family, who urge him to forget the past and become the man he wishes to be. This is Lethe. But there is no Eunoë. No river restores to Ashley the memory of a good deed, because no such memory survives the unmasking: the loyalty he believed virtuous was the product

of a lie, and the grief he believed innocent was the mask of a crime. Ashley stands at the top of the mountain having been offered forgetfulness and denied restoration. The Dantean economy of memory — the erasure of guilt compensated by the return of merit — is left half-completed, and the half that is missing is the half that would have given him an identity to ascend with.

III.4 The inverted Cave

The allegory of the Cave (*Republic* VII, 514a–520a) describes prisoners who take for reality the shadows of artefacts carried along a wall by puppeteers (*thaumatopoioi*, 514b), and a prisoner who, released and dragged upward, comes to see the things themselves and finally the sun. Jean-Louis Baudry (1975) read the Cave as the archetype of the cinematic apparatus. Leá Monde is an inverted Cave. The Dark casts images — of the family, of the brigands, of the massacre — onto Ashley's mind, and those images claim to be truer than the life he lived in daylight. Here the shadows accuse the sun. The upper world of Valnain, the VKP's headquarters, is revealed as the true cave, whose puppeteers staged his loyalty; but the underworld that exposes them is itself a theatre of puppets, and no sun is found at the top of the ascent, only a cathedral that collapses.

The game's prefatory verse, which declares the body a vessel and a puppet bending to the soul's tyranny, mortal and compelled to feed upon the flesh of others, and concludes that the soul must therefore deceive, despise, and kill, is in this light an anthropology of the Cave. It locates the puppeteer not on the wall but within, and assigns to the soul the very operations — deceit, contempt, murder — that the VKP performed upon Ashley's.

III.5 The anti-Er

The *Republic* closes with the myth of Er (614b–621d), a soldier killed in battle who revives on his funeral pyre and reports what he saw in the land of the dead. The souls choose their next lives and then cross the plain of Lethe, where they drink from the river Ameles, "Unheeding," and forget; Er alone is forbidden to drink, so that he may return as a messenger (*angelos*, 614d). Ashley is the anti-Er. He enters the city of the dead and comes back, but not as a messenger. His report is never made; the report that the VKP receives in his stead names him a murderer; and he disappears.

Yet the myth of Er contains a figure who anticipates Ashley's end with uncanny exactness. The last soul to choose is that of Odysseus, which, "from the memory of its former toils" recovered from the love of honour, searches for a long time and finds, lying neglected, the life of a private man who minds his own business — *bion andros idiōtou apragmonos* (620c). The hero of cunning, having remembered what glory cost, chooses obscurity. Ashley,

having learned what loyalty cost, chooses vagrancy. The difference is that Odysseus's choice is followed by the waters of Ameles, and Ashley's is not. He must live the obscure life remembering, or rather bearing, what made it necessary.

III.6 Gnostic anamnesis inverted

Plato's doctrine of recollection (*Meno* 81b–86b; *Phaedo* 72e–77a) holds that learning is the recovery of what the soul knew before birth. Gnosticism radicalized the doctrine into a soteriology of awakening. In the "Hymn of the Pearl" preserved in the *Acts of Thomas* (108–113), a prince sent from the royal house of the East to retrieve a pearl guarded by a serpent in Egypt eats the Egyptians' food, forgets his origin and his mission, and falls into a deep sleep; a letter from his parents, flying to him in the form of an eagle, wakes him; he remembers who he is, seizes the pearl, and returns home to be clothed in a radiant garment that mirrors him. Hans Jonas (1958) identified the metaphors that organize this literature — the stranger, the fall, sleep, forgetting, and intoxication — and the pivotal figure of the call from without. The Hermetic *Poimandres* tradition gives intoxication its classic formulation: "Whither are you being borne, O men, drunken, having drained the unmixed wine of ignorance, which you cannot even bear?" (*Corpus Hermeticum* VII.1). The verbs are *pheresthai* and *pherein*: to be borne along, and to bear.

Every element recurs in *Vagrant Story*, and every one is inverted. Ashley enters Leá Monde through its only entrance, a wine cellar, as if descending into the intoxication that Gnostic literature associates with forgetting. Sydney Losstarot is the caller from without, a heretic whose visions wake Ashley from the sleep of his loyalty. But the call does not return him to a royal house. It returns him to a crime; and the crime is attested only by the caller. The Gnostic awakening presupposes a pleroma, a fullness of true origin to which the soul returns. In Leá Monde the pleroma is empty. The garment that awaits Ashley at the end is not a robe that mirrors his true self but a disguise: in the game's final scene he escapes wearing the likeness of Callo Merlose. The Gnostic narrative of recollection ends in recognition; Matsuno's ends in a borrowed face.

The historical Gnosticism nearest to Matsuno's French source-landscape is Catharism, the dualist movement of Occitania suppressed by the Albigensian Crusade (1209–1229) and by the inquisitions that followed. Penitent heretics were sentenced to wear two yellow crosses of cloth, one on the breast and one between the shoulders, as the inquisitor Bernard Gui's *Practica inquisitionis* (c. 1323–1324) prescribes in its formularies. The heretics of St. Iocus were carved with an inverted cross as an abjuration of the flesh — a fitting sentence for dualists who already despised it. What the Inquisition

inscribed as penance, its victims, according to the game, renamed the Blood-Sin and made the key to a power. The penal cross between the shoulders, legible to everyone but its wearer, is the historical prototype of the tattoo on Sydney Losstarot's back.

III.7 Augustine: the fields of memory and the sin of blood

Augustine is the philosopher who first made memory the site of selfhood and of God. *Et venio in campos et lata praetoria memoriae*, "and I come to the fields and spacious palaces of memory" (*Confessiones* X.8.12), where the treasures of innumerable images are stored; and yet the same memory is a stranger to its owner: *factus eram ipse mihi magna quaestio*, "I had become a great question to myself" (IV.4.9). Ashley is Augustine's great question given an institutional answer. The halls of his memory were furnished by another.

The Augustinian doctrine that bears most directly on the game, however, is original sin. Against Pelagius, who held that Adam's sin passes to his descendants by imitation, Augustine held that it passes by generation: a guilt inherited through the blood, prior to any personal act and any personal memory. The Blood-Sin is a *peccatum sanguinis* in precisely this sense. It descends through a lineage — Hardin speaks of the cursed Müllenkamp bloodline that the Duke hopes to end — and its bearers are guilty, or marked, before they have done anything. But Augustine's theology also contains the remedy for inherited guilt, and it is not a genealogical remedy but an adoptive one: *accepistis Spiritum adoptionis filiorum*, "you have received the spirit of adoption as sons" (Romans 8:15; cf. Galatians 4:5). Redemption comes not by a better birth but by election into a new filiation. *Vagrant Story* reproduces this passage from generation to adoption with startling fidelity. The key passes first by blood, from the Duke to Sydney, who calls him father; and then by choice, from Sydney to a stranger whom he designates and tests. The Blood-Sin, originally a sin transmitted by generation, ends as a charge conferred by adoption.

III.8 The Grand Inquisitor and the heart-knower

In Ivan Karamazov's poem of the Grand Inquisitor (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, Book V, ch. 5), the aged cardinal tells the returned Christ that the Church has corrected his work: it has relieved humanity of the unbearable burden of freedom by giving it miracle, mystery, and authority, and its leaders consent to bear alone the knowledge that the consolation they administer is a lie. The Inquisitor is the purest theorist of the noble lie as a burden borne by its tellers. The VKP is his secular heir: it gave Ashley the happiness of a righteous grief and kept the truth to itself. Guildenstern is the Inquisitor's

degenerate successor, who seeks the Church's ultimate secret not to bear it for others but to wield it. And Sydney is an inverted Inquisitor: he too bears a secret and administers a deception — the masquerade by which he pursues the destruction of the city — but his secret is not a consoling lie; it is a mark, and his deception serves not the preservation of a power but its dissolution.

Callo Merlose's role becomes legible against the same background. In the New Testament God alone is *kardiognōstēs*, knower of hearts (Acts 1:24; 15:8), and the canonists accordingly held that *Ecclesia de occultis non iudicat* — the Church does not judge hidden things. Leá Monde grants the divine prerogative to a secular inquisitor, an analyst of religious terrorism employed by the state. What she does with it is instructive. She reads the heart of her captor, John Hardin, and finds not guilt to be prosecuted but a history of betrayal and grief — the comrades he sold for a promise of freedom that was never honoured, the gravely ill younger brother who died while he sat in prison. Hardin stabs his own leg to seal his mind against her; she persists, and her knowledge becomes intimacy rather than evidence. And it is Callo, the one character who can see into hearts, who insists that seeing into a heart does not certify what it reports. The heart-knower is the text's epistemic conscience.

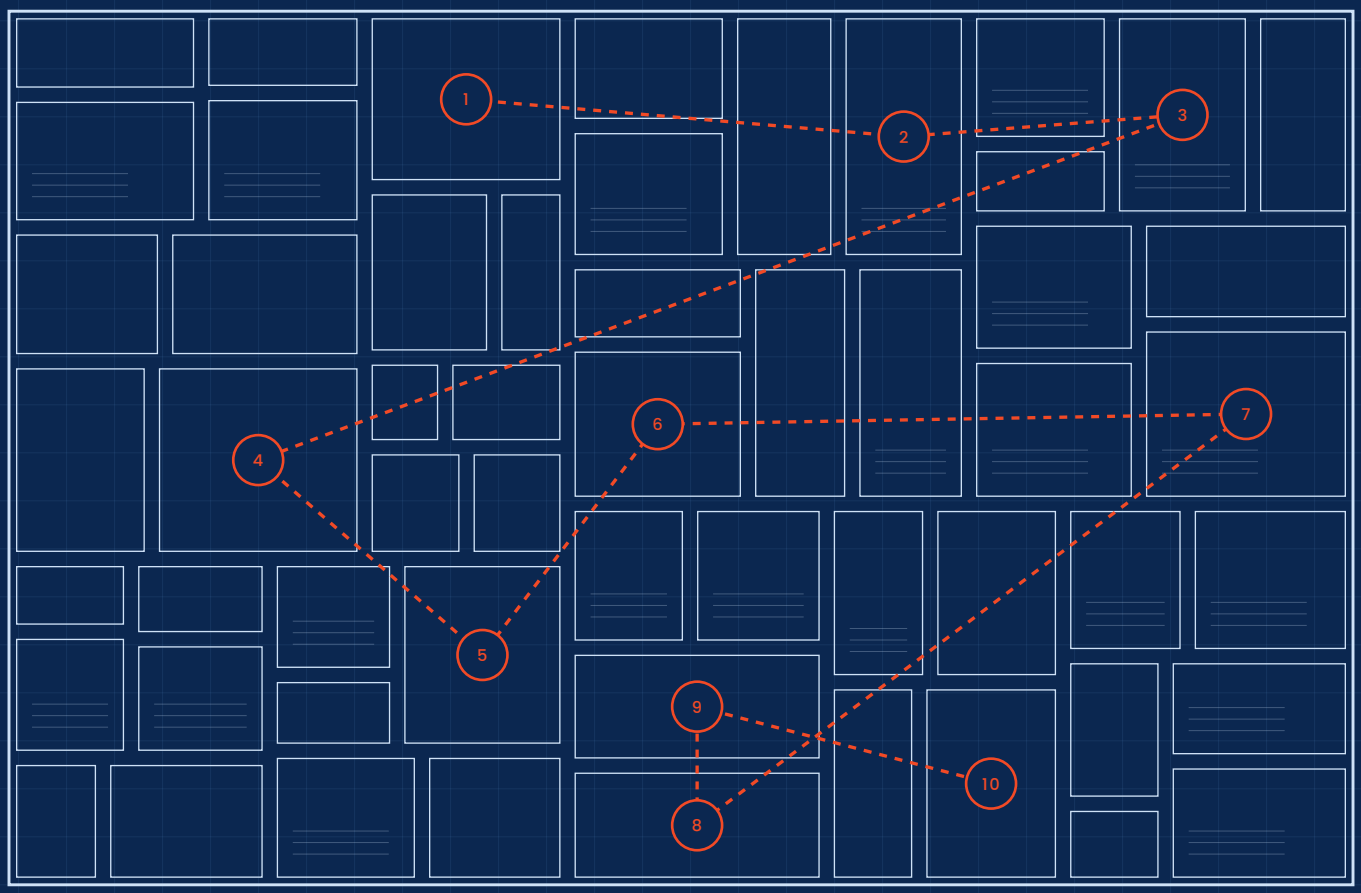
III.9 *Hamlet*: the forged ghost and the sealed commission

The names Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, and the forename Romeo, place *Vagrant Story* in explicit conversation with Shakespeare, and *Hamlet* in particular supplies the matrix of its central situation. Hamlet's father's ghost commands "Remember me" (1.5.91); the phantoms of Ashley's family, at the climax, command the opposite. Shakespeare's tragedy is driven by a spectral injunction to memory; Matsuno's ends with a spectral injunction to forget. Hamlet, moreover, doubts his ghost — "The spirit that I have seen / May be a devil" (2.2) — and stages a play to test its testimony. Callo's doubt about Sydney is Hamlet's doubt, and Leá Monde, a city that stages the past, is the mousetrap; but in *Vagrant Story* no king starts up from his seat to confirm the ghost's account, and the test never concludes.

The deepest correspondence lies in Act 5. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern carry to England a sealed commission they cannot read, which orders Hamlet's death; Hamlet opens it, forges a replacement ordering the death of its bearers, and seals it with his father's signet — "I had my father's signet in my purse" (5.2) — so that the two men carry their own sentence without knowing it. The Blood-Sin on Sydney's back is such a sealed commission: a text borne by one who cannot read it, which determines his fate and passes by his body to another. And Sydney's final masquerade, in which he enters the Duke's chamber wearing Ashley's likeness, is Hamlet's forgery transposed

to the register of the body. An identity is counterfeited and sealed with the father's authority to complete the father's command, and the counterfeit condemns an innocent — here Ashley, whose name the VKP report will bear. Tom Stoppard's *Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead* (1966) made the two courtiers into men who do not know what story they are in; Matsuno assigns their names to the two men in *Vagrant Story* who most covet the key, and who die for it without ever understanding the purpose it served.

"The time is out of joint" (1.5). Gilles Deleuze (1968) read Hamlet's line as the formula of a caesura, the moment at which an act too great for the self splits time into a before and an after and the self with it. Ashley's act — the killing — was too great for him, and the institution that commissioned it split his time by giving him an after without its before. *Vagrant Story* restores the before without restoring its certainty. The self it leaves standing on the far side of the caesura cannot remember itself into wholeness. It can only carry the joint.



LOCI — PLACES USED AS WAX, IMAGES AS LETTERS

THE MNEMONIST'S WALK

CHAPTER FOUR

HYLOMNESIS

Leá Monde as a Ruined Memory Palace

IV

IV.1 The city as book
IV.2 Grimoires that are eaten
IV.3 Simonides at civic scale
IV.4 From memory art to memory magic
IV.5 Freud's Rome and the Mystic Writing-Pad
IV.6 Ruin and allegory
IV.7 Saint-Émilion and the geology of the dead
IV.8 Hylomnesis
IV.9 From wine to blood

Leá Monde is a memory palace built by catastrophe and abandoned by its rememberer. This chapter reads the city through the classical art of memory, its Renaissance transformation into magic, Freud's topographies of the psyche, and Benjamin's theory of ruin, and introduces the dissertation's account of what the game calls the Dark: *hylomnesis*, the memory of matter, which remembers on behalf of a psyche that has been made to forget.

IV.1 The city as book

The game's most extravagant revelation is that the Gran Grimoire, the ultimate codex of sorcery for which Cardinal, Parliament, and cult contend, is not a volume housed in the city but the city itself: its walls are carved throughout with Kildean letters, and its power is concentrated in the Great Cathedral at its centre. The name of the city already said as much. Leá Monde is audibly *le monde*, the world, and a city named the World that turns out to be a book reactivates one of the oldest figures of Western thought, the *liber mundi*. *Omnis mundi creatura / quasi liber et pictura / nobis est in speculum*, "every creature of the world is to us as a book and a picture and a mirror," wrote Alan of Lille in the twelfth century. Ernst Robert Curtius (1948) traced the book as symbol from antiquity to the Baroque, and Hans Blumenberg (1981) reconstructed the long history of the world's *Lesbarkeit*, its readability. Mallarmé gave the figure its most radical modern turn: *tout, au monde, existe pour aboutir à un livre* — everything in the world exists in order to end in a book (1895).

Vagrant Story realizes Mallarmé's proposition with a literalism that becomes horrifying. The world of Leá Monde ended in a book: its five thousand inhabitants lived inside a text, and the earthquake that killed them, twenty-five years before the game begins, is best understood as the moment at which the text was executed upon its readers. When Ashley asks Sydney who caused the catastrophe, Sydney deflects the question to the sacrificed. The deflection is the only answer the city gives, and it locates the origin of the Gran Grimoire's power in a sacrifice whose agent is never named.

IV.2 Grimoires that are eaten

The game's lesser grimoires obey a rule that ought to be stranger than players find it. Dropped by defeated enemies, each grimoire is consumed in the act of reading: the book vanishes and the spell remains in Ashley's repertoire, payable thereafter in magic points. The historical *Grand Grimoire* — the French chapbook of demonic pact, also circulated as *Le Dragon rouge*, whose modern history Owen Davies (2009) has traced — was a book one kept, hid, and feared; Matsuno's grimoires are books one digests.

The rule inverts the founding myth of writing in Western philosophy. In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b) the Egyptian king Thamus rejects the god Theuth's gift of letters on the ground that writing is a drug, a *pharmakon*, "not of memory but of reminding" (*ouk oun mnēmēs alla hypomnēseōs pharmakon*, 275a): it externalizes memory and so weakens it. Jacques Derrida (1968) made this *pharmakon* — at once remedy and poison — the emblem of writing's undecidable relation to the living memory it supplements. The grimoires of *Vagrant Story* reverse Thamus's complaint. External writing becomes internal capacity by being destroyed; the text is annihilated precisely as it becomes memory. Their prototype is not the book but the scroll the prophet is commanded to eat, sweet as honey in the mouth (Ezekiel 3:1–3) and bitter in the belly (Revelation 10:9–10). And the operation is exactly the operation of the implant. The VKP gave Ashley a text — a story of brigands and a murdered family — that disappeared as text in the act of becoming his memory. A consumed grimoire leaves a spell and no book. An implanted memory leaves a grief and no author.

IV.3 Simonides at civic scale

The classical art of memory begins with a collapse. Cicero (*De oratore* II.86.351–354) tells how the poet Simonides of Ceos, dining at the house of Scopas in Thessaly, was called outside by two young men who wished to speak with him; while he was absent the roof of the banqueting hall fell, crushing the guests so completely that their kin could not identify the bodies. Simonides identified them by remembering the places at which each had reclined, and from this he inferred the principle of the art: that order is the chief aid of memory, and that one should use places in the way of wax tablets and images in the way of letters, *locis pro cera, simulacris pro litteris*. Quintilian (*Institutio oratoria* XI.2.17–22) describes the practice of storing images in the successive rooms of a large house; the anonymous *Rhetorica ad Herennium* (III.16–24) systematizes places (*loci*) and images (*imagines*), and prescribes that the images be *imagines agentes*, active and striking, beautiful or hideous, and above all disfigured — *cruentam aut caeno oblitam*, "stained with blood or smeared with mud" (III.22.37) — so that they will not be forgotten.

Leá Monde is Simonides's banquet hall at the scale of a city. An earthquake brought down the roof on five thousand guests. The city's rooms, each of which bears its own proper name and is recorded on Ashley's map as he enters it, are *loci*. The corpses reanimated by the Dark, bloodied, mutilated, and animate, are *imagines agentes* in the most literal sense the Latin permits: active images, disfigured precisely as the *Ad Herennium* recommends, stationed in the places where they fell. What Leá Monde lacks is Simonides: a survivor who remembers where each guest reclined and can restore their names. No one remembers the five thousand. They remember themselves — they rise in their places — and the player, walking from named room to named room and filling in the map, performs the mnemonist's labour without ever being told whom the images represent. The map of Leá Monde is a memory palace whose images have lost their referents.

IV.4 From memory art to memory magic

Frances Yates (1966) showed how, in the Renaissance, the rhetorical art of memory was transformed into an occult one. Giulio Camillo's memory theatre (*L'idea del theatro*, 1550) was to contain, in its tiers and images, the whole of knowledge available to whoever entered it; Giordano Bruno's *De umbris idearum* (1582) fused the art with Hermetic magic, making its combinatory wheels of images into instruments for organizing, and acting upon, the psyche. Mary Carruthers (1990; 1998) restored to the medieval art its character as a craft of thought, a *machina memorialis* for composition rather than storage. Leá Monde belongs to the late, magical phase of this history. Its memory is not a storehouse but an engine: the Gran Grimoire, carved into the city's fabric, does not merely preserve images but animates them, and whoever masters its centre masters the dead. The step from Camillo's theatre to Bruno's magic is the step from a place that contains memory to a place that uses it. That step, in Bruno, leads directly to the politics of manipulation analyzed in the next chapter.

IV.5 Freud's Rome and the Mystic Writing-Pad

In the first chapter of *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930), Freud asks the reader to imagine Rome as a psychical entity in which nothing that has once come into existence has passed away — in which every phase of the city's building coexists in the same space — and then abandons the analogy as absurd for a city, though apt for the mind. Leá Monde is Freud's impossible Rome realized. In the Dark, the city's strata coexist: the Kildean priesthood of Müllenkamp, the Inquisition of St. Iocus, the dead of the earthquake, and the living intruders of the present week occupy one space and act upon one another.

Freud's note on the "Mystic Writing-Pad" (1925) offers a second model. The toy consists of a celluloid sheet over waxed paper over a slab of wax: writing appears on the surface and can be erased by lifting the sheet, while the slab beneath retains every trace. The surface receives; the depth keeps. The tattoo is the anti-Wunderblock. Its surface retains permanently what the depth has been made to lose. Ashley's psyche has been treated as an erasable surface; the enduring trace lies elsewhere — in his hands' skill, in the Blood-Sin, in the stones of the city. Three further Freudian concepts are indispensable. The *screen memory* (1899) is a memory whose vivid but trivial content conceals, by displacement, a significant one; Ashley's grief-memory is a screen memory manufactured by an institution rather than by repression. *Nachträglichkeit*, deferred action, names the retroactive investiture of a past event with meaning; the Dark performs *Nachträglichkeit* on Ashley's past twenty years late. And the *repetition compulsion* of *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) describes the return of what has not been worked through as action rather than as memory: the undead of Leá Monde are repetition compulsion embodied, the unmetabolized past returning in the form of bodies.

Finally, "The Uncanny" (1919), drawing on Otto Rank's study of the double (1914), identifies the *Doppelgänger* as the return of something familiar that ought to have remained hidden. *Vagrant Story* makes the double an instrument of misattribution. Sydney's appearance before the Duke in Ashley's likeness is the event that makes Ashley the recorded murderer; Ashley's escape in Callo's likeness is the act that removes him from the record. In Leá Monde the uncanny is not only a feeling but a juridical fact. The double frames.

IV.6 Ruin and allegory

Walter Benjamin's study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928) located the allegorical imagination of the Baroque in a vision of history as irresistible decay, and gave that vision its emblem: *Allegorien sind im Reiche der Gedanken, was Ruinen im Reiche der Dinge* — allegories are in the realm of thoughts what ruins are in the realm of things. Leá Monde is Benjamin's ruin as a playable space: a landscape in which history has become setting, and in which every object signifies something other than itself — the wine cellar a descent, the quarry a grave, the cathedral a codex. Georg Simmel's essay on the ruin (1907) read it as the site where the balance between spirit and nature tips toward nature, the revenge of matter upon the forms the spirit imposed on it. Leá Monde inverts Simmel. In its ruins the balance tips the other way: spirit, in the form of the Dark, reclaims matter, animating stone and corpse alike. Pierre Nora (1984–1992) distinguished the *lieux de mémoire*, sites where memory is deliberately crystallized, from the living *milieux de mémoire* whose disappearance calls such sites into being. Leá Monde is a *lieu de mémoire* whose *milieu* — five thousand people — was obliterated in an afternoon. But it is a monument of a strange kind: it does not commemorate. It remembers aggressively, and the living enter it at their peril.

IV.7 Saint-Émilion and the geology of the dead

The attested source of Leá Monde's architecture is the town of Saint-Émilion, in the Bordeaux wine country, whose photographs captivated the design team and prompted a journey to France. The town's documented topography reads like the game's underground itinerary: a monolithic church hewn from the rock in the Middle Ages; a hermitage in a grotto associated with the eighth-century hermit Émilion, from whom the town takes its name; and a honeycomb of limestone quarries beneath the streets, many of them now serving as wine cellars. The jurisdiction of Saint-Émilion was inscribed on UNESCO's World Heritage list as a cultural landscape in 1999, while the game was in development.

One geological fact gives the source a significance the design team need not have intended. Limestone is a sedimentary rock composed largely of the calcareous remains of marine organisms; the plateau of Saint-Émilion is famous for its *calcaire à astéries*, a marine limestone rich in fossil fragments of sea creatures. A city quarried from limestone is a city built out of the dead. Leá Monde's Limestone Quarry and its Abandoned Mines are, at the level of matter, what its undead are at the level of narrative: the compacted past of innumerable bodies, raised into architecture. The Dark does not import memory into the city's stone. It awakens a memory the stone already was.

IV.8

Hylomnesis

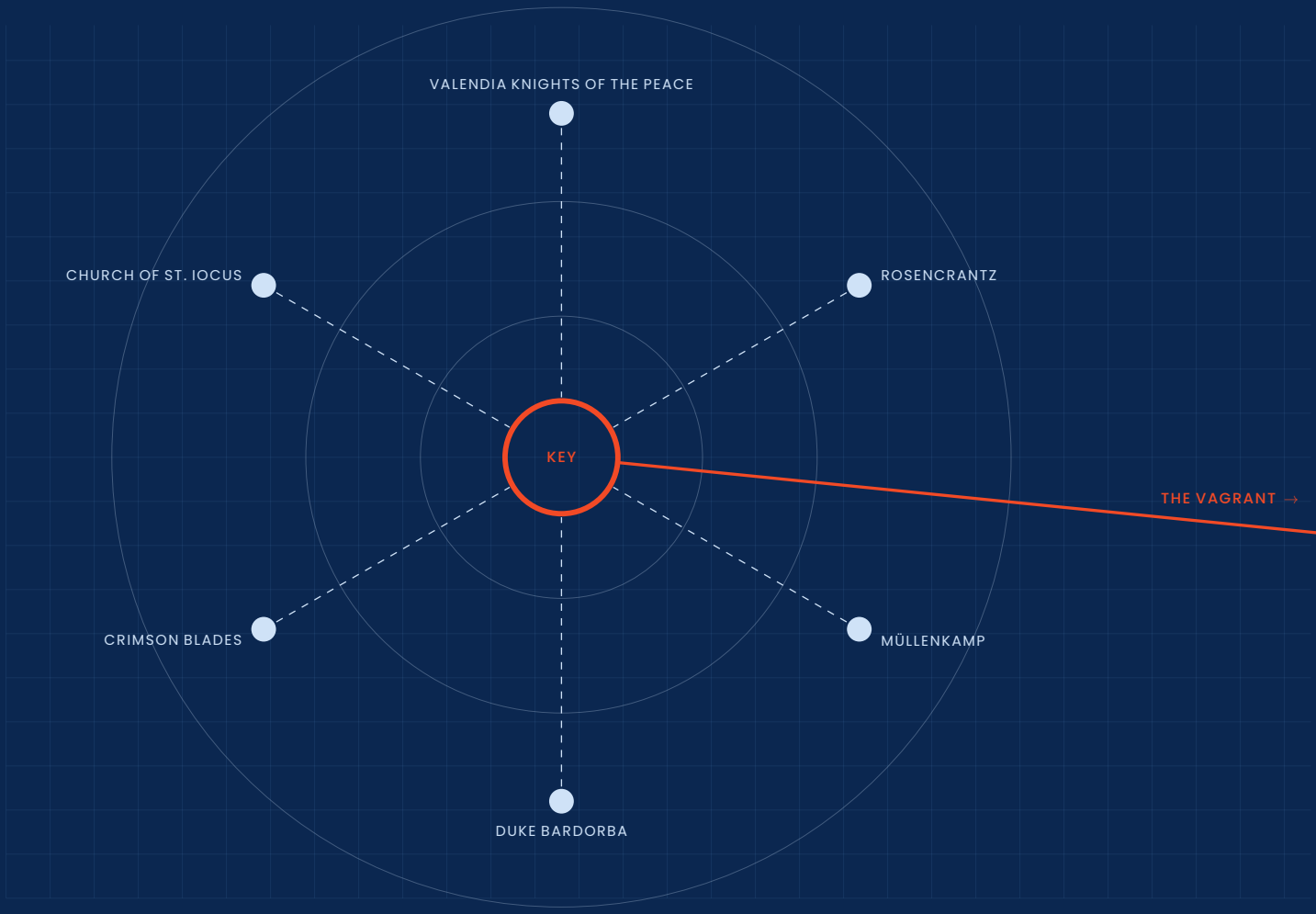
The term *hylomnesis* (from Greek *hylē*, matter, and *mnēsis*, remembering) names the operation that the Dark performs throughout the game: the retention and reenactment of the past by matter rather than by mind. It is defined against Henri Bergson, whose *Matière et mémoire* (1896) distinguished habit memory, sedimented in the motor mechanisms of the body, from pure memory, the spiritual survival of the past as such, and held that matter, being a present that is always beginning again, does not remember. Leá Monde inverts Bergson. In the Dark, matter remembers and spirit forgets. The minds that entered the city — Ashley's above all — arrive stripped of their past; the stones, the corpses, and the carved walls preserve it, and return it in the form of animated bodies and visions. Memory has migrated from the subject to the world, and the subject must go to the world to learn what he is.

Two features of the game's design mark the limits of hylomnesis. The first is its darkness. Tanizaki Jun'ichirō's *In Praise of Shadows* (1933) praised the Japanese aesthetic in which objects reveal their age, their patina, and their use only in dimness, and Leá Monde, lit by torchlight and deep shadow, is an architecture of patina: its darkness is the medium in which matter shows its memory. The second is the block puzzle. The rooms in which Ashley must push, stack, and climb cubes to advance are Cartesian interludes, zones of pure extension in which matter is indifferent geometry, without history. They are the only places in Leá Monde where matter forgets — and the game refuses to let them remain so. When Ashley returns to a solved puzzle room, it becomes a time trial titled "Evolve, or Die!!", in which the forgetful geometry is reinscribed with duration and ranked. Even the city's amnesiac chambers are made, on second visit, to keep time.

IV.9

From wine to blood

The itinerary of Leá Monde runs from a wine cellar, its only entrance, to a cathedral whose secret is a sin of blood. The sequence recapitulates, in inverted form, the central Christian rite of memory. At the Last Supper Christ gives the cup as *sanguis meus novi testamenti*, "my blood of the new covenant" (Matthew 26:28), and commands the rite to be done *in meam commemorationem* (Luke 22:19) — in Greek, *eis tēn emēn anamnēsin*, "for my anamnesis." Wine, in the Eucharist, is the matter of remembrance: an element that, consecrated, remembers a sacrifice on behalf of those who consume it. That is hylomnesis in its sacramental form, and Leá Monde's descent begins in its element. But the Eucharistic anamnesis remembers an origin — a sacrifice whose agent and meaning are known and proclaimed. Ashley's anamnesis, begun in a cellar of wine, ends at a mark of blood whose origin is withheld: the sacrificed, Sydney says, are the only ones who could answer. The rite of memory has been emptied of its founding event. What remains is the matter that remembers, and the mark that must be borne.



CHAPTER FIVE

MNEMONIC SOVEREIGNTY

The Blood-Sin and the Politics of the Past

V

V.1 Sovereign is he who decides on the past
V.2 The contest of jurisdictions
V.3 Weber: the succession of a gift
V.4 Kantorowicz: the dignity that does not die
V.5 Foucault: the soul as prison, and the forged instrument
V.6 Agamben: bare life and the undead
V.7 Benjamin: violence and the end of the city
V.8 Bruno's bonds: the magician as sovereign
V.9 Guildenstern, Robespierre, and the sacrificial crisis
V.10 A genealogy of the stigma
V.11 The deposition of the key

Every power in *Vagrant Story* contends not for territory but for jurisdiction over the past. This chapter formulates the principle that governs the contest — *sovereign is he who decides on the past* — by reworking Carl Schmitt's definition of sovereignty and testing it against Weber's theory of charismatic succession, Kantorowicz's theory of the undying dignity, Foucault's account of the disciplinary soul, Agamben's bare life, Benjamin's critique of violence, and Ioan Couliano's reading of Giordano Bruno as a theorist of manipulation. It then reconstructs the genealogy of the mark that stands at the centre of the contest, the Blood-Sin, and argues that the game's ending does not overthrow mnemonic sovereignty but deprives it of its instrument.

V.1 Sovereign is he who decides on the past

Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) opens with the sentence *Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*: sovereign is he who decides on the state of exception. The sovereign is defined not by the ordinary administration of norms but by the power to suspend them — to decide when the normal order no longer applies. The past, in *Vagrant Story*, is the temporal counterpart of the exception. It is the one domain in which the normal order of evidence cannot be applied, because the evidence has perished, been forged, or survives only in the testimony of the interested; and whoever decides what happened in that domain exercises a power prior to law, for law presupposes facts. The reformulation this dissertation proposes — *sovereign is he who decides on the past* — names that power. It is exercised when the VKP decides who killed Ashley's family, when the Church decides who was a heretic, when a bloodline decides who inherits a guilt, and when the VKP, at the end, decides who killed the Duke. In each case the decision precedes and conditions every subsequent judgment of right and wrong. The theological structure Schmitt found secularized in modern concepts of the state appears here with its theology intact: the power to decide the past is the power, once reserved to God, to pronounce on the secrets of hearts.

V.2 The contest of jurisdictions

The factions of the game can be sorted by the past each claims the right to decide, the instrument by which it decides, and its relation to the key.

CLAIMANT	PAST IT CLAIMS TO DECIDE	INSTRUMENT	RELATION TO THE KEY	FATE
Valendia Knights of the Peace	Ashley's biography; the official account of the Duke's death	Implanted memory; the investigative report	Investigates the Duke's dealings with the cult	Loses its agent; its final report names the wrong killer
Church of St. Iocus (Cardinal Batistum)	The history of heresy and the Inquisition	The Rood Inverse; the heresy-hunting Knights of the Cross	Covets the Dark as a path to immortality	Its knights fall in the city
Crimson Blades (Romeo Guildenstern)	The future, by purgation of the present	Terror; sacrifice	Seizes the key from Sydney	Defeated by Ashley
Duke Bardorba	His bloodline's past, and its ending	Secret financing of the cult; per the Ultimania, a soul shared with his son	Bearer, jointly with Sydney	Dies after killing Sydney
Müllenkamp (Sydney Losstarot, John Hardin)	The Kildean past of Leá Monde	Visions; the Blood-Sin	Sydney bears it; Hardin would perpetuate the legacy	Hardin dies outside the walls; Sydney dies in the epilogue
Jan Rosencrantz	Ashley's past, as his claimed former partner	Testimony	Demands to be named successor	Killed by Sydney

The table makes one feature of the game's politics conspicuous. Every claimant's instrument is a technique of the past — memory, record, mark, testimony, lineage, vision — and every claimant's fate is determined by the key. The civil war raging in Valendia during the game is never shown. Matsuno's camera stays in the city where the real contest is fought: the contest over who may write what happened.

V.3 Weber: the succession of a gift

Max Weber (1922) distinguished three types of legitimate domination — traditional, legal-rational, and charismatic — and devoted special attention to the crisis that charismatic authority undergoes at the death or disappearance of its bearer. Because charisma is a personal gift, its routinization requires a principle of succession, and Weber enumerated the possibilities: the search for a new bearer by signs, revelation by oracle, designation by the original bearer, designation by the charismatic staff, hereditary charisma (*Erbcharisma*), and office charisma (*Amtscharisma*), transmissible by ritual to whoever occupies a position.

The Blood-Sin is charisma in the etymological sense — a *charis*, a gift — and the game's plot is a succession crisis in which nearly every Weberian principle is tried. The key descends by hereditary charisma from the Duke to Sydney, who calls him father; Hardin, informed that the key-bearer is dying, speaks of assuming the legacy of the bloodline. Rosencrantz demands designation: he urges Sydney to perform the rites and name him successor. Guildenstern attempts usurpation under cover of office charisma, the authority of the Church in whose name he acts, and seals it with a sacrifice. Ashley receives the key by designation, after a trial: Sydney chooses him, tests him through the ordeal of the city, and, when Rosencrantz contests the choice, defends it. The succession that prevails is the least institutional of

the Weberian modes and the one closest to charisma's origin. It passes the gift from one bearer to another by a judgment of character, outside every structure — bloodline, office, church, or state — that would domesticate it.

V.4 Kantorowicz: the dignity that does not die

Ernst Kantorowicz (1957) reconstructed the medieval juristic doctrine by which the king possessed two bodies: a body natural, subject to infancy, age, and death, and a body politic, which never dies. *Dignitas non moritur*: the dignity does not die. French customary law expressed the same principle in the maxim *le mort saisit le vif*, the dead seizes the living, which ensured that succession occurred at the instant of death without interregnum.

The Blood-Sin is a *dignitas* in Kantorowicz's sense. Hardin states its governing anxiety precisely: if the key-bearer dies without a successor, all is lost. The dignity must not lapse. According to the Ultimania's supplementary account, flagged here as deutero-canonical, the Duke had joined his soul to Sydney's in infancy in order to save the child's life, so that the key was borne by one dignity in two bodies, and the death of either would entail the death of the other. The epilogue then reads as a juristic ceremony. Sydney, having secured a successor, enters the chamber; the Duke, declaring the work finished and leaving the rest to the one his son has chosen, kills him and dies. The two bodies that bore one dignity fall together, and in that instant the dignity passes — *le mort saisit le vif* — to a living man who is not of the blood, who is not present, and who will never claim it. Kantorowicz's doctrine served to perpetuate a sovereignty. In *Vagrant Story* it is used to extinguish one: the dignity survives, but only by passing into hands that refuse to rule.

V.5 Foucault: the soul as prison, and the forged instrument

Plato has Socrates cite the saying that the body (*sōma*) is the tomb (*sēma*) of the soul (*Cratylus* 400c; cf. *Phaedo* 82e). Michel Foucault inverted the formula in *Surveiller et punir* (1975): *l'âme, prison du corps*. The modern soul, on Foucault's account, is not a metaphysical substance but a reality produced by disciplinary power, a correlative of techniques of surveillance, training, and correction, which it then uses to govern the body it inhabits. *Vagrant Story* dramatizes this inversion with a precision that the game's own epigraph announces. Its prefatory verse, paraphrased, declares the body a vessel and a puppet that bends to the soul's tyranny, and concludes that the soul, compelled to feed on the flesh of others, must deceive, despise, and kill. The VKP's procedure is the Foucauldian soul-craft this verse describes. Confronted with a body that had killed, the institution manufactured a soul for it — a grieving, righteous, loyal soul — and used that soul to govern the body's further killing. Ian Hacking's memoro-politics names the specific

technology: the fabrication of a remembered past as an instrument of government.

The game supplies its own emblem of a counterfeit history of punishment. The hidden dungeon unlocked on a second playthrough is named the Iron Maiden, after the most notorious instrument in the popular imagination of medieval torture. Historians widely regard the iron maiden as an invention of the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries — a device first described in a story of a sixteenth-century execution published by Johann Philipp Siebenkees in 1793, and later assembled from disparate artefacts for exhibition. The emblem of premodern cruelty is itself a fabricated memory. That Matsuno's deepest dungeon, the reward for repetition, bears the name of a forged instrument of punishment is, whether or not it was so intended, the game's most exact joke about its own subject.

The Riskbreakers themselves belong to a later configuration of power. Their name makes them agents of what Ulrich Beck (1986) called the risk society, in which government is increasingly the management and distribution of hazards. A Riskbreaker is deployed to neutralize threats to the state; he is himself a managed hazard, expendable and deniable, working alone with a mortality rate the game describes as nearly suicidal; and, as Chapter VI shows, he carries his own risk as a quantified bodily ledger.

V.6 Agamben: bare life and the undead

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) identified at the foundation of sovereignty the figure of archaic Roman law who may be killed by anyone without the killing counting as homicide, yet who may not be sacrificed: bare life, included in the political order only by its exclusion. The undead of Leá Monde are bare life in its purest imaginable form. Suspended in what Guildenstern calls incomplete death, neither alive nor dead, they may be destroyed endlessly and without consequence; their destruction is not murder, and it is not sacrifice. They inhabit a zone of exception in a second sense as well: Leá Monde is a space outside the ordinary order of Valendia, into which the Cardinal's knights have entered without the approval of the VKP, and in which every faction acts beyond the law that would otherwise bind it.

The Riskbreaker is the state-side counterpart of the undead: a life the state may spend without accounting for it. It is therefore significant that the game contains exactly one sacrifice in the strict sense. Guildenstern, having taken the key, kills his lover Samantha as the offering the power of the Dark requires. He restores the sacrificial logic that sovereignty, in Agamben's account, had abandoned in favour of the ban — and he is destroyed. The game does not permit a return to sacrifice as a foundation of power. What it permits instead is the subject of Chapter VIII: a power borne but not exercised.

V.7 Benjamin: violence and the end of the city

Walter Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) distinguished law-making from law-preserving violence, and both — the violence Benjamin called mythic — from a divine violence that destroys law rather than founding or preserving it. Where mythic violence is bloody, divine violence is, in Benjamin's phrase, *auf unblutige Weise letal*: lethal in a bloodless way. The categories map the game's violence with some exactness. The VKP's founding lie is law-making violence exercised upon a soul; the Riskbreakers are law-preserving violence incarnate; Guildenstern's project, the institution of a regime of justice through fear, is law-making violence in its most naked form. The collapse of Leá Monde at the game's close belongs to none of these. It founds nothing and preserves nothing. It dissolves the Gran Grimoire, releases the dead from their incomplete death, and causes the creatures of the city to vanish — an end to a law of the Dark that sheds no further blood. The application of Benjamin's messianic category to a fictional catastrophe is analogical, and is offered as such; but the analogy identifies what is distinctive in the ending. It is not a victory. It is a deposition.

V.8 Bruno's bonds: the magician as sovereign

Ioan Petru Couliano's *Eros and Magic in the Renaissance* (1984) argued that Giordano Bruno's late treatise *De vinculis in genere*, "On Bonds in General" (c. 1588–1591), is a manual of manipulation: the magician binds individuals and masses by means of phantasms charged with erotic energy, and Couliano saw in this theory the prototype of the modern state's techniques of propaganda and mass persuasion — a magician-state. The VKP's implant is a Brunian *vinculum*. It binds Ashley by a phantasm, the image of a wife and son, charged with love and grief, and directs the resulting energy toward the state's ends. Sydney is a counter-magician who binds by the same means: he too works through visions, and he too seeks to direct Ashley toward a purpose he has chosen for him. Mnemonic sovereignty, seen through Couliano's Bruno, is sovereignty over phantasms. The game's last act of magic — Ashley's escape in the likeness of Callo — is the first in which the phantasm is wielded by the one it once bound.

V.9 Guildenstern, Robespierre, and the sacrificial crisis

Guildenstern's political creed, delivered as he seizes the key, holds that the nobility is idle and corrupt, that it steals men's dreams and twists them into nightmares, and that the corruption must be cleansed by a justice that does not waver and is enforced by fear. The speech is Robespierre's, transposed. On 5 February 1794, in his report on the principles of political morality, Robespierre defined the revolutionary government by the conjunction of *la vertu, sans laquelle la terreur est funeste; la terreur, sans laquelle la vertu est impuissante* — virtue, without which terror is baneful; terror, without which virtue is powerless. Guildenstern is the Incorruptible as crusader: pious, immune by his faith to the corrupting Dark, and for that very reason the character most dangerous in its possession.

René Girard's *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) described the sacrificial crisis, in which the erosion of differences breeds mimetic doubles whose rivalry can be resolved only by the expulsion of a surrogate victim. *Vagrant Story* is populated by doubles. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern arrive as a Shakespearean pair; Rosencrantz claims Ashley as his former partner and rival; Guildenstern and Sydney contend for the same key; Sydney wears Ashley's face and Ashley wears Callo's. Samantha is Guildenstern's surrogate victim, and her sacrifice is his attempt to resolve the crisis by the ancient means. The game's resolution is anti-sacrificial: the crisis ends not by an expulsion but by a withdrawal, as the object of rivalry passes to the one contender who does not desire it.

V.10 A genealogy of the stigma

The Blood-Sin condenses a long history of the mark as an instrument of sovereignty, and its genealogy illuminates the game's central transvaluation. In classical Greek, a *stigma* was a mark pricked or burned into the skin of slaves, criminals, and captives; C. P. Jones (1987) showed that ancient penal *stigmata* were more often tattoos than brands. Sovereignty over the mark could extend even to matter: Herodotus reports having heard that Xerxes, enraged at the Hellespont, sent men to brand it (7.35). The Roman army tattooed its recruits, and Vegetius records that soldiers, inscribed in the skin with marks that endure, swore their military oath — their *sacramentum* — when entered on the rolls (*Epitoma rei militaris* I.8; II.5). An edict of Constantine (*Codex Theodosianus* 9.40.2, 315/316) forbade marking the faces of those condemned to the arena or the mines, since the face was formed in the likeness of heavenly beauty, and directed that the mark be placed on hands or calves instead.

Christianity performed the first great transvaluation. Paul, closing his letter to the Galatians, writes that he bears in his body the marks of Jesus: *ego*

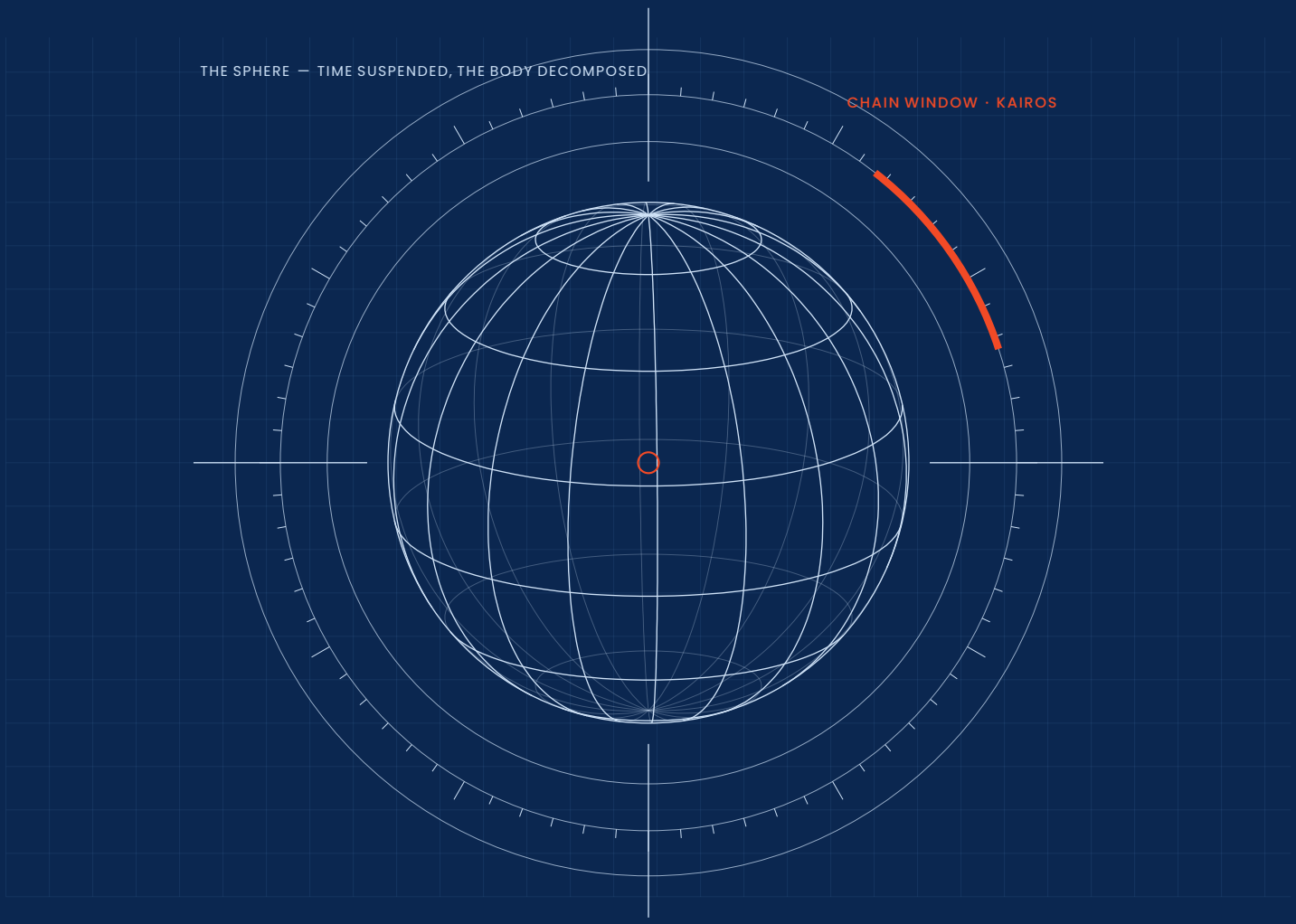
enim stigmata Domini Iesu in corpore meo porto (6:17), where the Greek verb is *bastazō*, to carry. The slave's brand of ownership becomes the apostle's sign of belonging, borne as a burden and a title at once. The same letter enjoins its readers to bear one another's burdens (*alter alterius onera portate*, 6:2) and warns that each shall bear his own (6:5). Francis of Assisi received the stigmata at La Verna in 1224, and the mark of punishment became the highest sign of sanctity. Early modern sovereignty reversed the transvaluation. The statute of 1547 that Marx cites in the chapter of *Capital* on the "bloody legislation" against the expropriated ordered that a vagabond idle for three days be branded with a V on the breast, and that a runaway condemned to slavery be branded with an S on the forehead or the back (Marx 1867, ch. 28). In Nathaniel Hawthorne's *The Scarlet Letter* (1850), finally, the penal letter worn on Hester Prynne's breast is slowly reinterpreted by the community — some come to say that it means *Able* — until the mark of shame becomes a sign of strength.

The Rood Inverse carries this entire history in a single sign. The inverted cross is by tradition the cross of Peter, who asked to be crucified head-downward as unworthy to die as his master died — a sign of humility that later centuries came to read as a sign of apostasy. The sign itself underwent a chiasmus before the game begins. In the fiction, the Inquisition of St. Iocus carved it into heretics as an abjuration of the flesh, a penal mark; the heretics renamed it the Blood-Sin and made it the key to the power of Leá Monde. Two opposed chiasmi now define the game's politics of the mark. The first is the state's: it converts a deed into a wound, turning Ashley's killing into his bereavement and concealing agency beneath suffering. The second is the heretics': it converts a wound into a key, turning a penal brand into a source of power and disclosing, beneath suffering, a capacity. Neither chiasmus restores an origin. The first falsifies the past; the second transvalues it.

V.11 The deposition of the key

At the end of *Vagrant Story*, every institution that claimed jurisdiction over the past has lost its hold on the key. The VKP has lost its agent and files a report that misnames a murderer. The Church has lost its knights and its Cardinal's hope of immortality. Parliament has lost the Duke. The cult has lost its leader and his deputy. Rosencrantz's claim to designation has been refused, and Guildenstern's usurpation defeated. The key rests with a man who is recorded as a criminal and is never found.

Mnemonic sovereignty has not been overthrown; the VKP's report shows that the power to decide the past persists and continues to decide it falsely. What has changed is that sovereignty has been deprived of its instrument. The key is borne by one who will not use it, in the power of no institution, and outside the archive that decides. That disposition — custody without exercise — is the political content of the game's ending, and the theory of it occupies Chapter VIII. Before that theory can be stated, however, it must be shown that the game does not merely narrate these arguments but makes its player perform them. That is the task of Chapter VI.



CHAPTER SIX

LUDIC FORM

A Game That Remembers in Its Hands

VI

VI.1 Against Bildung: growth without experience
VI.2 The weapon that remembers
VI.3 The hands remember: habit memory and the unsealed skills
VI.4 Break Arts: the mnemotechnics of pain
VI.5 Chains and *kairos*
VI.6 Risk: the somatic ledger
VI.7 The sphere: sovereignty over bodies in suspended time
VI.8 The back: dorsal legibility and the player's gaze
VI.9 The Dark as cinema; the world as script
VI.10 The magic circle and the memory card
VI.11 New Game+: the eternal return of what is carried
VI.12 The player as implanter

The mechanics of *Vagrant Story* do not illustrate its philosophy; they enact it. This chapter demonstrates, system by system, that the game's rules distribute memory away from the protagonist's mind and into his weapons, his body, his wounds, and the machine that records his progress, and that they place the player in the structural position of the institution the story indicts. In Ian Bogost's terms (2007), the procedural rhetoric of the game advances the same thesis as its narrative. Its mechanics and its story are not dissonant but consonant — the rare case of a work whose rules argue what its plot argues.

VI.1 Against Bildung: growth without experience

The role-playing game inherited from the *Bildungsroman* a model of the self as the sum of its experiences: in Wilhelm Dilthey's classic account of the genre, a young man enters life, gathers experience, meets conflict, and matures into harmony with himself and the world. The experience point is that model quantified. Each deed deposits a residue in the self; the self grows by accumulation; and the level, the unit of maturation, certifies that the protagonist has become more himself. *Vagrant Story* abolishes the experience point. Ashley has no levels. His permanent attributes rise in discrete increments, chiefly upon the defeat of the city's greater powers and through rare elixirs, so that growth is not the sedimentation of experience but a series of transfers from the defeated — an economy closer to sacrifice than to education.

The abolition is thematically exact. A game about a man whose experiences were forged cannot certify selfhood by the accumulation of experience. Arnold van Gennep's *Les Rites de passage* (1909) described the tripartite structure of initiation — separation, margin, aggregation — and Victor Turner (1969) made the middle term, liminality, the condition of being betwixt and between. The traditional role-playing narrative completes the passage: the hero returns aggregated into a new status. Ashley is separated from the VKP and passes through the margin of Leá Monde, but he is never aggregated. He does not return to Valnain, and the record that would have reincorporated him names him a criminal. The vagrant is a permanent liminal, and the game's refusal of levels is the ludic form of that refusal of aggregation.

VI.2 The weapon that remembers

Where Ashley does not accumulate, his equipment does. Every weapon and piece of armour in *Vagrant Story* carries affinities toward classes of enemy — among them human, beast, undead, phantom, dragon, and evil — and toward the elements, and these affinities change with use: a blade grows keener against the kind of creature it is used upon, and may lose affinity in one respect as it gains it in another. In the city's workshops, weapons can be combined, merging their affinities and sometimes producing a new blade. The result is that the game's record of what Ashley has killed resides not in Ashley but in his weapons. A sword used against men acquires, measurably, an aptitude for men. The blade remembers what the mind of its wielder was made to forget.

Bernard Stiegler (1994) called such external supports *tertiary retention* — memory inscribed in technical objects, which he argued constitutes human beings as much as biological or neural memory does — and named the process *epiphylogenesis*, the accumulation of experience outside both genome and brain. André Leroi-Gourhan (1964–1965) had described the history of the species as the progressive exteriorization of memory into tools and writing. Merleau-Ponty's blind man, whose cane ceases to be an object and becomes an extension of his perceptual field (1945), shows the incorporation of such prostheses into the lived body. *Vagrant Story* takes these theses to their conclusion. Ashley's identity, so far as it consists in what he has done, is distributed across his armoury. His prostheses are the only honest archive of his violence, and the only one the VKP did not think to forge. The game's crafting system, often described as the most demanding in its genre, is in this light a forensic apparatus: its menus are the ledger in which the truth of killing is kept.

VI.3 The hands remember: habit memory and the unsealed skills

The story tells that the Dark unseals in Ashley combat skills he had hidden from himself, and the mechanics correspond: Chain Abilities and Defensive Abilities become available as the game proceeds, not as new learning but as recovered capacity. Bergson (1896) distinguished two survivals of the past: habit memory, sedimented as motor mechanisms in the body, which repeats; and pure memory, which represents. Ashley's pure memory has been counterfeited; his habit memory is intact, and it is the memory of the assassin. Marcel Mauss's "techniques of the body" (1934) and Pierre Bourdieu's *habitus* (1972; 1980) describe the social history that such bodily capacities carry within them. Ashley's *habitus* is the institutional history his mind was denied: every perfectly timed strike reenacts the training of an elite squad. The player who masters the chains therefore learns to perform the one form of Ashley's memory that was never falsified — and it is a memory of killing.

VI.4 Break Arts: the mnemotechnics of pain

Break Arts are special techniques, acquired weapon by weapon through accumulated kills, which inflict great damage at the cost of Ashley's own hit points. They are the game's most Nietzschean system. In the second essay of the *Genealogy of Morals* (1887), Nietzsche asks how a memory could be bred into the forgetful human animal — how one could raise *ein Thier, das versprechen darf*, an animal permitted to promise (II.1) — and answers that memory was burned in by pain: *Man brennt etwas ein, damit es im Gedächtnis bleibt: nur was nicht aufhört, weh zu tun, bleibt im Gedächtnis* — "something is burned in so that it stays in memory; only what does not cease to hurt stays in memory" (II.3). The history of punishment, on this account, is the history of mnemotechnics, and conscience is the scar tissue of the debtor's pain.

Break Arts invert the scene of punishment without leaving it. The wound is self-inflicted rather than imposed; it is learned by killing and paid for in the killer's own blood; and its product is not a memory in the mind but force in the world. They are, moreover, exempt from the game's accounting of Risk, discussed below: of all Ashley's violent acts, the ones that wound him are the only ones that do not expose him further. The mechanic proposes, in miniature, the stigmatophoric principle that the final chapter formalizes. What is paid for in one's own body is borne rather than risked; the wound one carries is the one form of violence that does not accumulate against the self.

VI.5 Chains and *kairos*

Chain Abilities are triggered by pressing a button within a narrow window at the moment a blow lands, and further abilities can be linked in succession, so that combat takes on the character of a rhythm game; Defensive Abilities are triggered, analogously, at the moment an enemy's blow arrives. The Greeks called the opportune instant *kairos*, and the Hippocratic *Aphorisms* open by warning that it is sharp and fleeting (*ho de kairos oxys*, 1.1). Edmund Husserl's lectures on internal time-consciousness (1905; published 1928) described the living present as structured by *retention*, the just-past still held in consciousness, and *protention*, the about-to-come already anticipated. The chain is a machine for training retention and protention: the player must hold the rhythm of the previous impact and anticipate the next, and the slightest failure of either breaks the sequence. The game thus locates Ashley's competence not in a remembered past but in a trained present — the thin interval where the just-past and the not-yet meet. A man whose past is unreliable is given, as his one incontestable mastery, the mastery of the instant.

VI.6 Risk: the somatic ledger

Beneath Ashley's hit points and magic points runs a third gauge, Risk. It rises as he attacks, and rises faster with chains and defensive abilities; while it is high, his accuracy and defence fall and enemy blows and spells strike harder; but the chance of critical hits rises, and so does the potency of his healing. Risk is a ledger kept in the body. It records the intensity of violence sustained, it exacts its price in vulnerability, and it pays a paradoxical dividend: the most exposed Ashley is also the one most capable of an extraordinary strike and of an extraordinary recovery.

The gauge gives quantitative form to three traditions at once. It is Greek *hybris* made arithmetical — excess that invites its own nemesis. It is the individual correlate of Ulrich Beck's risk society, in which hazards are produced, distributed, and managed as the ordinary business of government; the Riskbreaker, an officer of that government, carries its accounts on his own person. And it is Nietzsche's creditor–debtor relation (*Genealogy* II.4–8) internalized: every blow drawn upon the body's credit accrues interest in exposure. That the Break Arts, paid for in blood, are exempt from this ledger completes the argument of the previous section. The one debt that does not accrue is the one paid at once, in the body, by the one who owes it.

VI.7 The sphere: sovereignty over bodies in suspended time

When Ashley attacks, time stops. A wireframe sphere appears around him, marking the range of his weapon, and within it the bodies of his enemies are decomposed into targetable parts — head, torso, arms, legs — each with its own vulnerability and its own consequence when struck. The system is pausable real time: the flow of the world is suspended while the player decides where the blow will fall.

The sphere is the diagram of sovereignty developed in Chapter V. Its suspension of time is the exception in ludic form: the decision is made outside the ordinary flow, in a frozen present that belongs to the one who decides. Its decomposition of the enemy into zones is what Foucault called anatomo-politics — the body analysed into parts, each with its function and its point of application — and its visual language, the transparent wireframe over the living figure, recalls the anatomical plates of Vesalius's *De humani corporis fabrica* (1543), in which the body is opened to the knowing eye. The player, in the sphere, exercises over every body in the city the power the VKP exercised over Ashley: the power to decide, in a suspended time, how a person will be marked.

VI.8 The back: dorsal legibility and the player's gaze

The third-person camera of *Vagrant Story* habitually frames Ashley from behind; the player may switch to a first-person view to look around, but the game is played, for the most part, over the protagonist's shoulder. This convention, common in three-dimensional games, acquires in this game a precise meaning. The Blood-Sin is a mark on the back — on Sydney's back, where Guildenstern recognizes it and where Sydney cannot see it — and the back is the one region of the body that its owner can never read. Sartre's analysis of the look (1943) made the experience of being seen from where one cannot see oneself the origin of shame and of the self's objectification; Lacan (1964) described the gaze as that which regards the subject from a point he cannot occupy; Merleau-Ponty's late work made the invisible side of the visible body a constitutive dimension of perception.

The player occupies exactly that point. For the entire game, the player looks at the region of Ashley's body where the mark of the key would be inscribed, from the position from which alone such a mark is legible. This is the condition this dissertation calls *dorsal legibility*: the inscription that constitutes a self is legible to others and not to the self. And the position of the reader of the back is the position of the one who inscribed it — the tattooist, the inquisitor, the implanter. The camera places the player where the VKP stood.

VI.9 The Dark as cinema; the world as script

Vagrant Story renders its cutscenes in the game engine with the same character models used in play, so that there is no break between the cinematic and the playable: the story is staged in the world, with the world's materials. Within that staging, the Dark behaves as a cinematic apparatus. Ashley's clairvoyant visions of the Crimson Blades, advancing elsewhere in the city, are parallel montage — the cross-cutting that D. W. Griffith made the grammar of narrative cinema — attributed to a supernatural cause; his visions of his family are flashbacks whose authority the film cannot guarantee. Jean-Louis Baudry (1970; 1975) and Christian Metz (1975) argued that the cinematic apparatus produces its effects of reality by concealing its own operation. The Dark is an apparatus that does not conceal itself, and whose products are therefore always suspect.

The game has no voice acting. Its characters speak in comic-style speech balloons, drawn in the idiom of the European *bande dessinée*, which float within the rendered world. The choice has a philosophical consequence. In a city that is itself a grimoire, the inhabitants speak in writing; speech appears within the world already as script, legible and archivable. Jacques Derrida's *De la grammatologie* (1967) argued against the metaphysical priority of speech over writing that the living voice has never been the origin writing merely copies. Leá Monde is a grammatological world. There is no voice in it from which the written could be said to derive, just as there is no memory in Ashley from which the forged could be said to depart.

VI.10 The magic circle and the memory card

The game is saved at marked points in the city, and the save is written to the PlayStation's memory card, a removable block of 128 kilobytes on which the player's progress persists outside the machine. The memory card is the fiction's only faithful archive. It holds the week that the VKP's report falsifies. It knows that Ashley did not kill the Duke, because it holds the record of everything he did. The contrast between the two archives — the institutional report that misnames the murderer and the player's save file that preserves the truth — is the game's final statement about mnemonic sovereignty. The truth of the past survives, but it survives only outside the polity, in the private archive of the one who lived it through another's body.

VI.11 New Game+: the eternal return of what is carried

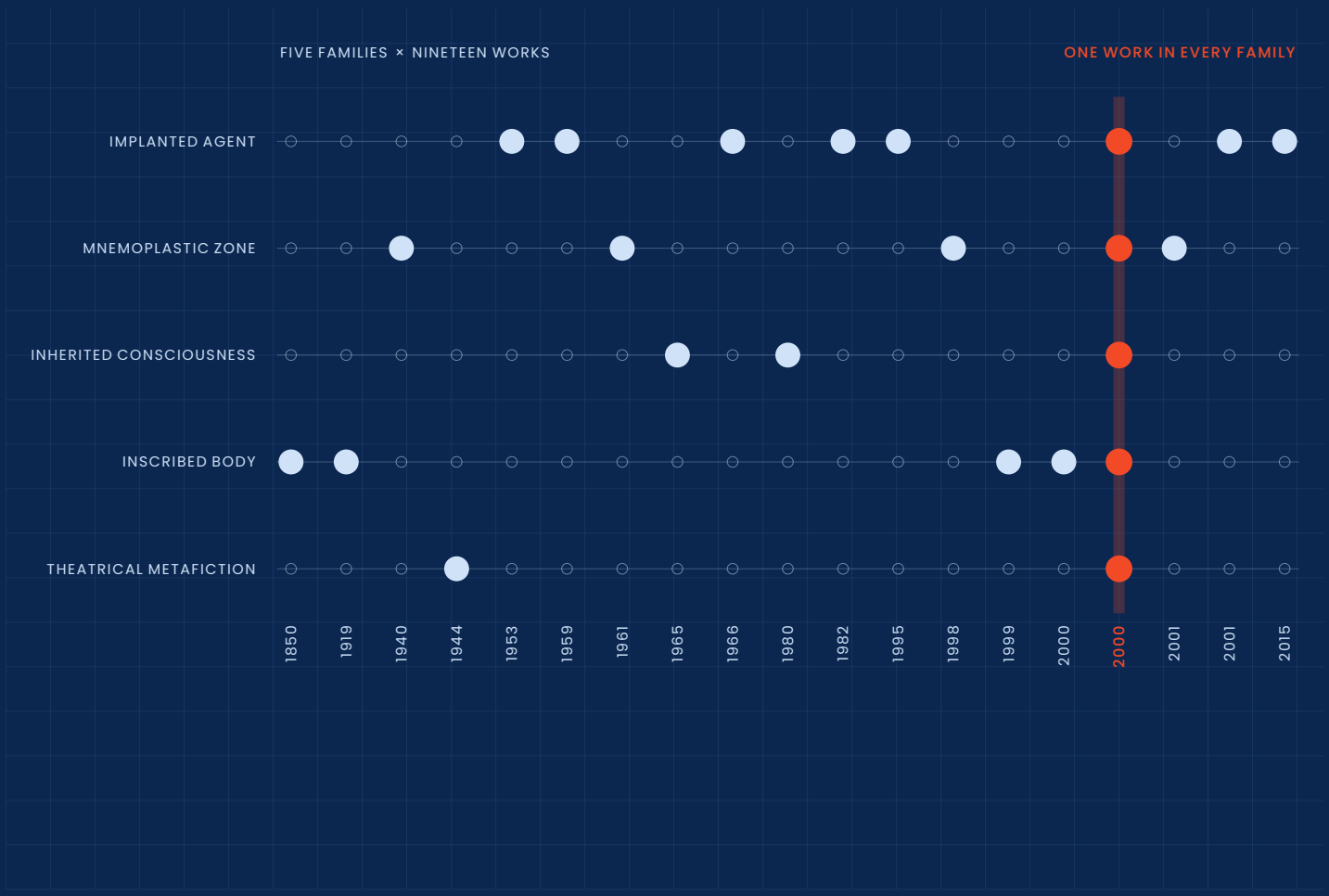
On completion, the game offers a New Game+, in which the story is replayed from the beginning, unchanged, while Ashley retains the weapons, armour, items, and attributes he possessed at the end; the repetition also opens the hidden Iron Maiden, a deeper dungeon with stronger enemies. Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) described genuine repetition as a recollection forward; Nietzsche framed the thought of eternal recurrence as *das grösste Schwergewicht*, the greatest weight (*Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §341), a burden whose bearing is the test of a life; Deleuze (1968) made repetition the production of difference.

New Game+ gives the Riskbreaker's question a mechanical answer. In the repetition, nothing that Ashley remembers carries over: the story does not change, the revelations recur as revelations, and he learns again, with the same astonishment, what he learned before. What carries over is what he carries — the arms he forged, the capacities his body acquired, the burden, in Nietzsche's word, of everything he bore. *Fero, ergo sum* is here a rule of the save file. Across the eternal return of the plot, the self that persists is the self that bears.

VI.12 The player as implanter

The avatar is, by its ontology, a body whose past was written by another and whose acts are performed by another. Pirandello's *Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore* (1921) and Unamuno's *Niebla* (1914), in which the protagonist confronts the author who has decided his death, dramatized the fictional person's dependence on an authoring will; Janet Murray (1997), Espen Aarseth (1997), Jesper Juul (2005), Alexander Galloway (2006), and Brendan Keogh (2018) have theorized the distinctive forms of that dependence in interactive media. *Vagrant Story* turns the dependence into its subject. The VKP's relation to Ashley — to write his past and direct his violence toward ends he does not choose — is the relation of designer and player to any avatar. The player, too, makes Ashley kill; the player, too, experiences that killing as righteous, as progress, as the heroism of a loyal agent pursuing a cult. When the game reveals that Ashley's righteousness was manufactured, the revelation reaches past the character to the one holding the controller.

The game therefore indicts its own form, and it does so without irony or sermon. It gives the player the only honest archive of the week, and the only position from which the dorsal mark can be read; and it gives the player the power of the sphere, the exception, and the implant. The player is at once the witness who can refute the VKP and the operator who resembles it. That doubled position — faithful archivist and heterographer at once — is the position from which the theory of the final chapters must be read.



CHAPTER SEVEN

A COMPARATIVE TYPOLOGY OF THE IMPLANTED PAST

VII

VII.1 The implanted agent
VII.2 The mnemoplastic zone
VII.3 Inherited consciousness
VII.4 The inscribed body
VII.5 Theatrical metafiction
VII.6 The bearer who does not use
VII.7 A structural convergence: *Dark Souls*
VII.8 The typology

Speculative and philosophical fiction has imagined the falsified past in five principal forms, and it has imagined four dispositions toward it: restoration, rejection, submission, and — in *Vagrant Story* almost alone — assumption. This chapter constructs the typology, family by family, and locates Matsuno's work within it. The comparisons are constellations in Benjamin's sense; no claim of influence is made except where noted.

VII.1 The implanted agent

The first family concerns a person, usually an agent of some power, whose memories have been fabricated by that power. Its founding texts are Philip K. Dick's. In "Impostor" (1953), Spence Olham, accused of being an alien replica carrying a bomb, flees to prove his humanity, finds the corpse of the real Olham, and in the instant of recognizing that he is the replica, detonates: recognition of the implant is annihilation. In "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966), Douglas Quail buys an implanted memory of a secret mission to Mars and discovers that he really was a government assassin whose memory the government erased; the story then turns the screw again, revealing that the fantasy chosen to replace the erased memory was also true. Quail is Ashley's nearest ancestor — an assassin whose past was erased by his employer — but Dick's recursion ends in confirmation: every implant uncovers a real past beneath it. Paul Verhoeven's *Total Recall* (1990) keeps the recursion and suspends the confirmation, leaving open whether the whole adventure is itself the purchased dream.

Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), filmed by Ridley Scott as *Blade Runner* (1982; revised 1992 and 2007), gives the replicant Rachael the implanted childhood memories of her maker's niece, and leaves its hunter, Deckard, suspended by the film's later cuts in doubt as to whether he too is a manufactured man. The morphology of the title — an agent noun built on an object, one who runs blades — is the morphology of Riskbreaker, one who breaks risks; both name officers of a state that hunts what it has made. In Richard Condon's *The Manchurian Candidate* (1959), filmed by John Frankenheimer (1962), captured American soldiers are conditioned to remember their sergeant, Raymond Shaw, as the hero who saved them, when under conditioning he had in fact killed two of their comrades; the truth surfaces in the nightmares of the officer Bennett Marco. The structure is chiastic memory in its collective form — a killer remembered as a saviour — and the dreamer of the truth bears, by a coincidence that no argument should rest on, the name of Ashley's phantom son.

Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995), after Masamune Shirow's manga, contains the purest instance of the implant as dispossession. A

garbage collector whose cyberbrain has been hacked believes he has a wife and a daughter he longs to see; investigators inform him that he lives alone and that his family never existed, and that the false memories cannot readily be removed. Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000), released in the same year as *Vagrant Story*, gives the family its most self-reflexive member. Leonard Shelby, unable to form new memories, reads his past from tattoos, among them a sentence about his wife's murder inked in reverse across his chest so that it can be read only in a mirror; the film suggests — through the account of the policeman Teddy, which it neither confirms nor refutes — that his wife survived the assault and died of an insulin overdose that Leonard himself administered, injection after injection, unable to remember the dose he had just given, and that he has displaced this act onto the story of another man, Sammy Jankis; and it reveals that he has knowingly falsified a clue so that his future self will kill Teddy. Leonard is a self-heterographer: he writes his own implant. Ashley receives his.

Hideo Kojima's *Metal Gear Solid 2: Sons of Liberty* (2001) turns the implant into a thesis about digital control of information and about the player. Its protagonist, Raiden, learns that his mission and much of his history were orchestrated, and at the close discards the dog tags that bear the personal details the player entered at the game's start: the implanted identity is cast off, and the player's with it. *Metal Gear Solid V: The Phantom Pain* (2015) reverses the gesture. Its protagonist is revealed to be a medic made, by surgery and hypnotic conditioning, to believe himself the legendary soldier Big Boss, and the face the player designed at the game's opening proves to be the face of the man so transformed; the medic accepts the phantom identity and lives it. That Kojima's title repeats the title Matsuno gave his plot fifteen years earlier is a coincidence this study does not attempt to explain. The two Japanese auteurs of the implanted self nonetheless define opposite poles. In Kojima, the implanted identity is either cast off (2001) or embraced as a role (2015). In Matsuno, it is neither cast off nor embraced. It is assumed as a burden whose truth cannot be known.

VII.2 The mnemoplastic zone

The second family concerns places that materialize memory — zones in which the past, and above all guilt, returns as matter. In Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961; filmed by Andrei Tarkovsky, 1972), the planet's ocean sends the scientists of the station "visitors" fashioned from their memories; Kris Kelvin receives the likeness of his wife, who killed herself after he left her. The ocean is hylomnesis on a planetary scale, and like the Dark it returns what the subject has buried rather than what he has chosen. In Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972), filmed by Tarkovsky as *Stalker* (1979), a room at the heart of the Zone grants the innermost wish rather than the professed one; the stalker Porcupine, who entered to save his brother, returns rich, and hangs himself. The Zone, like Leá Monde, discloses to its visitors the truth of their desire. Alex Proyas's *Dark City* (1998) imagines a city whose inhabitants' memories are rewritten each midnight by the Strangers, who "tune" the architecture and the biographies together; its hero seeks a seaside town, Shell Beach, that everyone remembers and no one can reach. J. G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962) makes a flooded London a trigger for the regression of its explorers into the biological memory of the species. Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014) sets at the centre of its zone a tower whose walls bear a text written in living organic matter — a *liber mundi* in which the letters are alive.

The zone has a game lineage contemporaneous with Matsuno's. *Planescape: Torment* (Black Isle, 1999) opens with an amnesiac immortal waking in a mortuary; his companion reads to him the instructions tattooed on his back by a previous incarnation — the most exact analogue in any medium to the dorsal legibility of the Blood-Sin. The Nameless One's past self is at once himself and another; the game asks what can change the nature of a man, and its answer is a chosen acceptance of responsibility for the crimes of prior selves. Konami's *Silent Hill 2* (2001) sends James Sunderland into a town that materializes his repressed guilt for the death of his wife; the town is a mnemoplastic zone organized, like Leá Monde, around a killing its visitor has made himself forget. Jorge Luis Borges supplies the family's metaphysics. The City of the Immortals in "El inmortal" (1947) is an architecture without purpose, and its narrator learns that his memories are composed of the words of others. In "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940), a fictitious world's history displaces the real one in the schools, until a fictitious past occupies memory in place of another of which nothing is known with certainty — *ni siquiera que es falso*, not even that it is false. That clause is the most exact formulation in literature of what this dissertation calls anamnesis without origin. And Italo Calvino's *Le città invisibili* (1972) contains Zora, a city so perfectly memorized that it was forced to remain motionless and so vanished, and Eusapia, whose

living have built an underground copy of the city for the dead — until no one can say which city copies which.

VII.3 Inherited consciousness

The third family concerns memories received from ancestors or predecessors. In Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), the Reverend Mothers of the Bene Gesserit, by transmuting the Water of Life, gain access to the memories of their female ancestors, while the order's Missionaria Protectiva has for centuries seeded planets with legends of a coming saviour — a manufactured religious past waiting to be exploited. Herbert thus joins in one institution the two operations that *Vagrant Story* distributes: the inheritance of memory and the sovereign manufacture of it. Gene Wolfe's *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–1983) is narrated by Severian, a journeyman of the guild of torturers — the Order of the Seekers for Truth and Penitence — who claims perfect memory and yet proves an unreliable witness; at a ritual feast he consumes, with a drug called the alzabo, the flesh of the woman he loved and thereafter carries her memories within him, and on becoming Autarch he receives the consciousness of his predecessors. Wolfe's eaten memory is the dark twin of Matsuno's eaten grimoire. Ubisoft's *Assassin's Creed* (2007) makes genetic memory the object of extraction by a corporate order descended from the Templars — an institutional mining of the ancestral past that shares Vagrant Story's suspicion of every order that would possess it.

VII.4 The inscribed body

The fourth family concerns the mark. Hawthorne's *The Scarlet Letter* (1850), discussed in Chapter V, is its paradigm of transvaluation: a penal letter reinterpreted by its bearer's life. Franz Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919) is its paradigm of the unreadable sentence. The condemned man does not know his sentence; the apparatus lays him face-down and its harrow writes the violated commandment into his back over twelve hours, and the writing is the execution: he deciphers it only through his wounds, toward the sixth hour, and at the twelfth the machine kills him and casts his body into a pit; when the officer submits himself to the machine with the sentence *Sei gerecht!* — Be just! — it breaks down and kills him without inscription. Kafka's apparatus is the institutional counterpart of the Blood-Sin: a script written on the back, unreadable by its bearer except through suffering. The difference is the one on which Chapter VIII turns: Kafka's sentence becomes legible only as it kills its bearer, while the Blood-Sin is carried, unread, by a bearer who lives. Ray Bradbury's *The Illustrated Man* (1951) covers its title figure with living tattoos that enact stories for whoever watches, and leaves a blank area in which an observer may see his own future. Margaret Atwood's *The Hand-*

maid's Tale (1985) marks its narrator's ankle with digits and an eye, the tattoo of state ownership. China Miéville's *Perdido Street Station* (2000) imagines the Remade, criminals punished by the fusion of their bodies with machines and animal parts — sentences inscribed as flesh.

VII.5 Theatrical metafiction

The fifth family concerns the self as a role in a script written by another. *Hamlet* and Tom Stoppard's *Rosencrantz and Guildenstern Are Dead* (1966) have been discussed in Chapter III. Its most exact analogue to *Vagrant Story*, however, is Borges's "Tema del traidor y del héroe" (1944). An Irish conspirator, Fergus Kilpatrick, is discovered by his comrades to be a traitor; rather than expose him and damage their cause, they have him killed in a staged assassination scripted from *Julius Caesar* and *Macbeth*, so that the traitor is remembered as a martyred hero. A century later his descendant uncovers the Shakespearean borrowings, understands the fabrication, and decides to publish a book glorifying the hero — a decision, the story suggests, that the conspirators may themselves have foreseen. The traitor remembered as a hero, the history staged from Shakespeare, the historian who uncovers the forgery and keeps it — every element recurs in Matsuno, transposed. In Borges the institution makes a traitor into a hero; in Valendia it makes a killer into a mourner and, at the end, an innocent into a murderer. The Shakespearean names, in both, are the forger's signature.

VII.6 The bearer who does not use

One further constellation clarifies the ending. In J. R. R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* (1954–1955), the Ring-bearer carries a power whose use would corrupt him, in order that it may be destroyed; near the end, when he can no longer walk, his companion carries him up the mountain. Ashley, at the end of *Vagrant Story*, carries the wounded Sydney out of the collapsing city while bearing the key. But the difference is decisive. Frodo bears the Ring toward its destruction, and at the brink fails to relinquish it; the story ends when the power ceases to exist. The Blood-Sin is not destroyed. Ashley bears it without an appointed end, and the story ends while the power persists. Tolkien imagines a custody that terminates in annihilation. Matsuno imagines a custody without end, the form of which Chapter VIII names custodial inoperativity.

VII.7 A structural convergence: *Dark Souls*

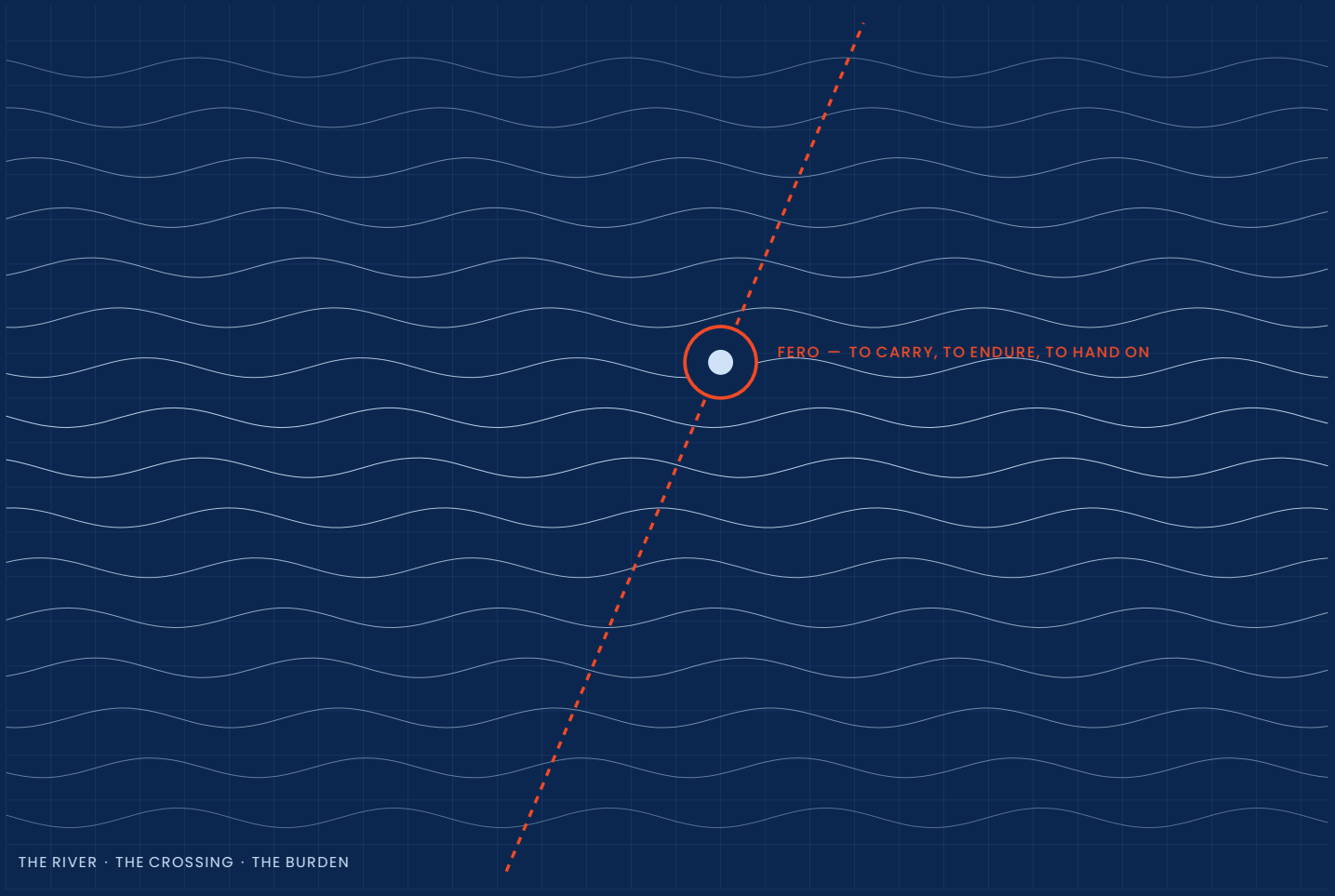
FromSoftware's *Dark Souls* (2011) converges with *Vagrant Story* in structure, though no influence is claimed here. Its protagonist bears the Darksign, a brand of undeath that marks him as one of the cursed; its world is an interlocking ruin in which every district remembers a fallen order; its dead return endlessly; and at its close the player chooses between rekindling an age of fire and inaugurating an age of the Dark, a choice urged upon him by rival powers each of which claims to disclose the true history of the world. The convergence isolates Matsuno's singularity by contrast. *Dark Souls* ends in a sovereign choice between two dispensations. *Vagrant Story* ends by withdrawing the key from every dispensation.

VII.8 The typology

WORK (YEAR)	FAMILY	AUTHOR OF THE PAST	MEDIUM OF INSCRIPTION	DISPOSITION TOWARD THE IMPLANTED PAST
Hawthorne, *The Scarlet Letter* (1850)	Inscribed body	Puritan magistracy	Letter worn on the breast	Transvaluation by the bearer
Kafka, "In the Penal Colony" (1919)	Inscribed body	Penal apparatus	Sentence written into the back	Deciphered only through wounds
Borges, "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940)	Mnemoplastic zone	A secret society	Invented history taught in schools	Substitution; not even known to be false
Borges, "Theme of the Traitor and the Hero" (1944)	Theatrical metafiction	Conspirators	Staged death scripted from Shakespeare	Forgery uncovered and kept
Dick, "Impostor" (1953)	Implanted agent	Enemy power	Replica with false memories	Recognition as annihilation
Condon, *The Manchurian Candidate* (1959)	Implanted agent	Enemy conditioners	Collective false memory of heroism	Truth surfaces in dreams
Lem, *Solaris* (1961)	Mnemoplastic zone	The ocean	Visitors made from memory	Guilt materialized
Herbert, *Dune* (1965)	Inherited consciousness	Bene Gesserit	Other Memory; seeded legends	Inherited and exploited
Dick, "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966)	Implanted agent	The state	Erasure and implant	Recursion; implant confirms a real past
Wolfe, *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–1983)	Inherited consciousness	Ritual and office	Memories consumed with flesh	Assimilation
Blade Runner (1982)	Implanted agent	The corporation	Implanted childhood	Accepted; identity left undecidable
Ghost in the Shell (1995)	Implanted agent	An anonymous hacker	Hacked cyberbrain	Dispossession
Dark City (1998)	Mnemoplastic zone	The Strangers	Nightly rewriting of city and self	Revolt; the city remade
Planescape: Torment (1999)	Inscribed body	A former self	Tattoos on the back	Responsibility accepted for prior selves
Memento (2000)	Inscribed body	The self	Tattoos and notes	Self-heterography

WORK (YEAR)	FAMILY	AUTHOR OF THE PAST	MEDIUM OF INSCRIPTION	DISPOSITION TOWARD THE IMPLANTED PAST
Vagrant Story (2000)	All five	The state; the Church; the Dark	Implanted grief; the Blood-Sin	Assumption without verification
Silent Hill 2 (2001)	Mnemoplastic zone	The self's repression	A town made of guilt	Confession
Metal Gear Solid 2 (2001)	Implanted agent	An information order	Orchestrated mission; dog tags	Cast off
Metal Gear Solid V: The Phantom Pain (2015)	Implanted agent	A military legend's allies	Surgery and hypnosis	Embraced as a role

Read by its final column, the typology yields four dispositions. The first is *restoration*: the implant is removed and a true past recovered (Dick's recursions, the Square cycle's Cloud). The second is *rejection*: the implant is cast off and the self freed into self-authorship (Raiden, and in a darker key the revolt of *Dark City*). The third is *submission*: the implant is accepted as a role, tragically or pragmatically (the medic of *The Phantom Pain*, Leonard's chosen lie). The fourth is *assumption*, and in the corpus assembled here only *Vagrant Story* achieves it in pure form, with *Planescape: Torment* and *The Scarlet Letter* approaching it from either side. Assumption differs from restoration because no true past is recovered; from rejection because the mark is not cast off; and from submission because the subject does not live the implanted role but carries, knowingly, a past whose truth he cannot establish. *Vagrant Story* occupies every family at once, which is why it could invent the fourth disposition: it is the only work in the series in which the implanted agent, the mnemoplastic zone, the inherited mark, the inscribed body, and the Shakespearean script converge on one person, and in which the convergence leaves him with nothing to restore, nothing he could cast off, and no role he could consent to play — only a burden to bear. Chapter VIII formalizes the theory of that burden.



CHAPTER EIGHT

FERO, ERGO SUM

A Theory of Stigmatophoric Identity

VIII

VIII.1 The universal case and the extreme case
VIII.2 Twelve theses
VIII.3 A formal statement
VIII.4 The grammar of bearing
VIII.5 Objections and replies
VIII.6 Spectral forgiveness
VIII.7 Implications
VIII.8 The answer to the Riskbreaker's question

A self is constituted, in the last instance, not by what it thinks, remembers, or narrates, but by what it bears. This chapter states the theory that the preceding chapters extracted from *Vagrant Story* as a sequence of numbered theses, gives it a formal statement, defends it against six objections, and draws its implications for theology, the politics of memory, the study of games, and the study of speculative fiction.

VIII.1 The universal case and the extreme case

The theory begins not with Ashley but with everyone. No one remembers his own birth. Augustine, recounting his infancy in the *Confessions*, admits that he knows that age of his life only by the testimony of others and by inference from watching other infants: *quam me vixisse non memini, de qua aliis credidi* — "which I do not remember having lived, concerning which I have believed others" (I.7.12). Every self receives its name, its lineage, its language, and the fact and circumstances of its origin from others, and can verify none of them from within. The origin of every self is heterographic. Ashley's case is not an exception to the human condition but its extreme case: the case in which the others who testify to the origin are an institution, the testimony is false, the falsification serves the institution's ends, and its refutation arrives from interested parties and cannot be confirmed. *Vagrant Story* isolates, by exaggeration, the structure of every self.

VIII.2 Twelve theses

1 **Inscription.** The past that constitutes a self is present to it not as a record it consults but as an inscription it carries — a mark in the body, in the world, and in the archives of institutions.

2 **Heterography.** Every such inscription is at least in part written by others. The difference between the ordinary self and the Riskbreaker is one of degree and of intent, not of kind.

3 **Mnemonic sovereignty.** The power to inscribe the past of others is an elementary form of sovereignty, prior to law because law presupposes facts. Sovereign is he who decides on the past.

4 **Chiasmus and counter-chiasmus.** Domination characteristically converts a deed into a wound, concealing agency beneath suffering; resistance characteristically converts a wound into a key, disclosing capacity beneath suffering. Both are transvaluations. Neither restores an origin.

5 **Anamnesis without origin.** The unmasking of a forged past does not yield a true past. Where the only archive of a life is the life itself, and its refutation comes from the interested, the true past may be unavailable in principle and not merely in fact.

6 **The failure of the four principles.** Under heterography, identity cannot be grounded in self-transparent thought (*cogito*), in memory (*memini*), in narrative (*narro*), or in self-creation, for thought is read by others, memory is forged, the story is written elsewhere, and the self does not choose what it receives.

7 ***Fero, ergo sum.*** The self is constituted by the free and knowing assumption of an inscription that it did not author, cannot read by itself, and cannot verify. Its freedom lies not in what it bears but in bearing it.

8 **Immemorial responsibility.** Responsibility precedes and exceeds recollection. The unverifiability of a deed relocates responsibility rather than cancelling it: the stigmatophoric self answers for what it may have done, not because it remembers doing it, but because it carries the mark of having been made the kind of agent who could.

9 **Dorsal legibility.** The inscription that constitutes a self is legible to others and not to the self. Self-knowledge is structurally belated and borrowed; the other reads one's back.

10 **Forgiveness and promise.** Release from the demand to settle an unverifiable past can come only as a gift from outside the self, and it can be received even when its givers cannot be authenticated; fidelity to what is borne binds the future without a remembered origin. Together they constitute selfhood as self-constancy without sameness.

11 **Custodial inoperativity.** The highest form of bearing a power is to hold it without exercising it. A power so held is withdrawn from every sovereignty that would use it.

12 **Vagrancy.** The political form of the stigmatophoric self is exit from the archive: the refusal of every institution that claims the right to write the past upon another's body.

VIII.3 A formal statement

Let m range over inscriptions and x over subjects. Let $\mathrm{Inscr}(m, x)$ mean that m is inscribed upon x — in body, world, or record — as constitutive of x's past; $\mathrm{Auth}(x, m)$ that x authored m; $\mathrm{Leg}_x(m)$ that m is legible to x unaided; $\mathrm{Ver}_x(m)$ that x can verify what m states; and $\mathrm{Bear}(x, m)$ that x knowingly and freely assumes m as a charge, without claiming its authorship, its legibility, or its truth. Stigmatophoric identity is then defined by two clauses:

FORMAL STATEMENT

$$\mathrm{Stig}(x, m) \equiv \mathrm{Inscr}(m, x) \wedge \neg\mathrm{Auth}(x, m) \wedge \neg\mathrm{Leg}_x(m) \wedge \neg\mathrm{Ver}_x(m)$$
$$\mathrm{Self}(x) \Leftarrow \exists m\,[\,\mathrm{Stig}(x, m) \wedge \mathrm{Bear}(x, m)\,]$$

The first clause describes a condition that befalls a subject; the second states the thesis. The conditional is deliberately one-directional. The theory does not claim that bearing is the only ground of selfhood, only that it is sufficient where every other ground has failed — and Thesis 2 implies that every other ground fails, at the origin, for everyone.

VIII.4 The grammar of bearing

The choice of *ferre* over its rivals is grammatical before it is philosophical. *Patior*, I suffer, is purely passive; *ago*, I act, is purely active; *ferre* joins endurance and conveyance, suffering and transmission, in a single verb, and its Greek cognate *pherein* has a middle voice, *pheresthai*, in which the subject is caught up in the process it performs. Émile Benveniste (1950) characterized the middle diathesis as the voice in which the subject is the seat of the process, inside it rather than outside it. Stigmatophoric identity is a middle-voice identity: the self neither makes its mark nor merely undergoes it, but carries it, and is carried along by it. The Stoic distinction with which Epictetus opens the *Enchiridion* — *ta men estin eph' hēmin, ta de ouk eph' hēmin*, some things are up to us and some are not (1.1) — locates the freedom in question precisely. The mark is not up to us. The bearing is.

VIII.5 Objections and replies

Objection 1: this is existentialism. Heidegger's *Sein und Zeit* (1927) already describes the self as thrown (*geworfen*) into a situation it did not choose, as originally guilty (*schuldig*) in being the null basis of a nullity, and as achieving authenticity by taking over its thrownness; Sartre adds that the self makes itself from what it is given. *Reply.* Heideggerian thrownness is ontological and authorless: no one throws Dasein. Stigmatophoric inscription is ontic, political, and authored: an identifiable institution wrote Ashley's past, for identifiable ends. Heideggerian authenticity, moreover, is a recovery of mineness (*Jemeinigkeit*); stigmatophoric selfhood is constitutively not-mine, and remains so when assumed. And Sartrean self-creation is precisely what the game refuses: Ashley creates nothing; he carries.

Objection 2: to assume the mark is to consent to domination. A theory that counsels the bearing of an imposed inscription seems to ratify the power that imposed it, and to recommend a quietist *amor fati*. *Reply.* Assumption is not endorsement. Paul bore the slave's *stigmata* as a title, Hester Prynne bore her letter until it changed its meaning, and the heretics of St. Iocus bore the Rood Inverse until it became a key: in each case bearing changed the function of the mark. Nor is bearing Nietzsche's *amor fati*, the formula for wanting nothing to be otherwise; Ashley does not love his mark, and nothing in the game suggests he should. Harry Frankfurt's theory of identification (1971; 1976) makes a self's own the desires it wholeheartedly endorses; stigmatophoric assumption endorses nothing about the content of the mark. It accepts the weight and refuses the use.

Objection 3: the theory over-reads an elliptical plot. More than half of the planned story was cut; the ellipses are accidents of production, and interpretation should fill them from the Ultimania rather than build a philosophy upon them. *Reply.* Ellipsis is constitutive in any work that survives into its reception with its gaps. Friedrich Schlegel made the fragment a form in its own right, and Maurice Blanchot's *L'Écriture du désastre* (1980) argued that a writing faithful to catastrophe must be fragmentary. More decisively, the proposal to complete the game from an official guidebook is itself an instance of the phenomenon the game narrates: a past supplied to a subject by an authority external to him. An interpretation that respects the ellipses is the only one consistent with the work's own thesis.

Objection 4: why *fero*? If memory fails, why not a principle of suffering, *patior*, or of confession, *confiteor*? *Reply.* Suffering is passive and confession presupposes knowledge of what is confessed. *Ferre* alone names an activity compatible with ignorance of the content borne: one may carry a sealed letter, as Rosencrantz and Guildenstern did, and a mark on one's back, as Sydney did.

Objection 5: the theory excuses perpetrators. If the past cannot be verified, the killer may shelter behind uncertainty. *Reply.* The theory does the opposite. Emmanuel Levinas (1974) described a responsibility for the other that precedes every commitment, rooted in a past that was never present to consciousness. Stigmatophoric responsibility is of this immemorial kind: Ashley answers for a family he cannot remember killing and cannot verify having killed. The perpetrator who invokes uncertainty in order to disown a deed is refusing to bear; the stigmatophoric self invokes the same uncertainty and bears the deed regardless. The theory thus closes the loophole that memory-based accounts of responsibility leave open, in which want of consciousness excuses.

Objection 6: vagrancy is withdrawal from politics. A self that answers the politics of memory by walking away abandons the field to the sovereigns. *Reply.* Custody is a political act. A power withdrawn from use is a power denied to every claimant; the key in a vagrant's keeping is a key no Cardinal, Parliament, or cult can turn. Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri's *Empire* (2000), published in the same year as the game, proposed desertion and exodus as forms of refusal under a sovereignty without outside, and took Melville's Bartleby as an emblem of refusal. Bartleby's formula — "I would prefer not to" (1853) — is the grammar of custodial inoperativity. Giorgio Agamben (1993; 1999) read in it the potentiality not to, the capacity that preserves itself by not passing into act. Ashley's possession of the Blood-Sin is a potentiality that prefers not to.

VIII.6 Spectral forgiveness

Thesis 10 requires elaboration because it concerns the most enigmatic scene in the game. At its climax, the phantoms of the family urge Ashley to forget the past and become the man he wishes to be. The scene is a forgiveness, and a forgiveness of a peculiar kind. Hannah Arendt (1958) identified forgiveness as the remedy for the irreversibility of action and the promise as the remedy for its unpredictability; Vladimir Jankélévitch (1967; 1971) meditated on the imprescriptible, the crime that cannot be forgiven; Jacques Derrida (2001) argued that forgiveness, if it exists, forgives only the unforgivable. Ashley's forgiveness is *spectral* in a precise sense: it is offered by figures who may be the victims, may be his invented family, or may be products of the Dark, and whose authority to forgive therefore cannot be established. Its validity cannot rest on the identity of the forgivers. It rests instead on what it does. It does not absolve the deed, which remains unverified and borne. It releases Ashley from the demand to settle the past before he may act — from the demand that anamnesis reach its origin. Spectral forgiveness is the forgiveness appropriate to anamnesis without origin: a release that leaves the debt intact and the debtor free to carry it.

VIII.7 Implications

For theology. Augustine, arguing against the Donatists that baptism conferred by an unworthy minister remains valid, compared the baptismal character to the military mark that remains on a deserter's body (*Contra epistulam Parmeniani* II.13.29); Aquinas made the indelibility of sacramental character a doctrine (*Summa theologiae* III, q. 63, a. 5). Stigmatophoric identity is the secular heir of the *character indelebilis*: an identity conferred by a mark that persists independently of the bearer's worthiness, memory, or consent — with the difference that its conferring agency is not grace but power, and its sanctification, if any, comes only from how it is borne.

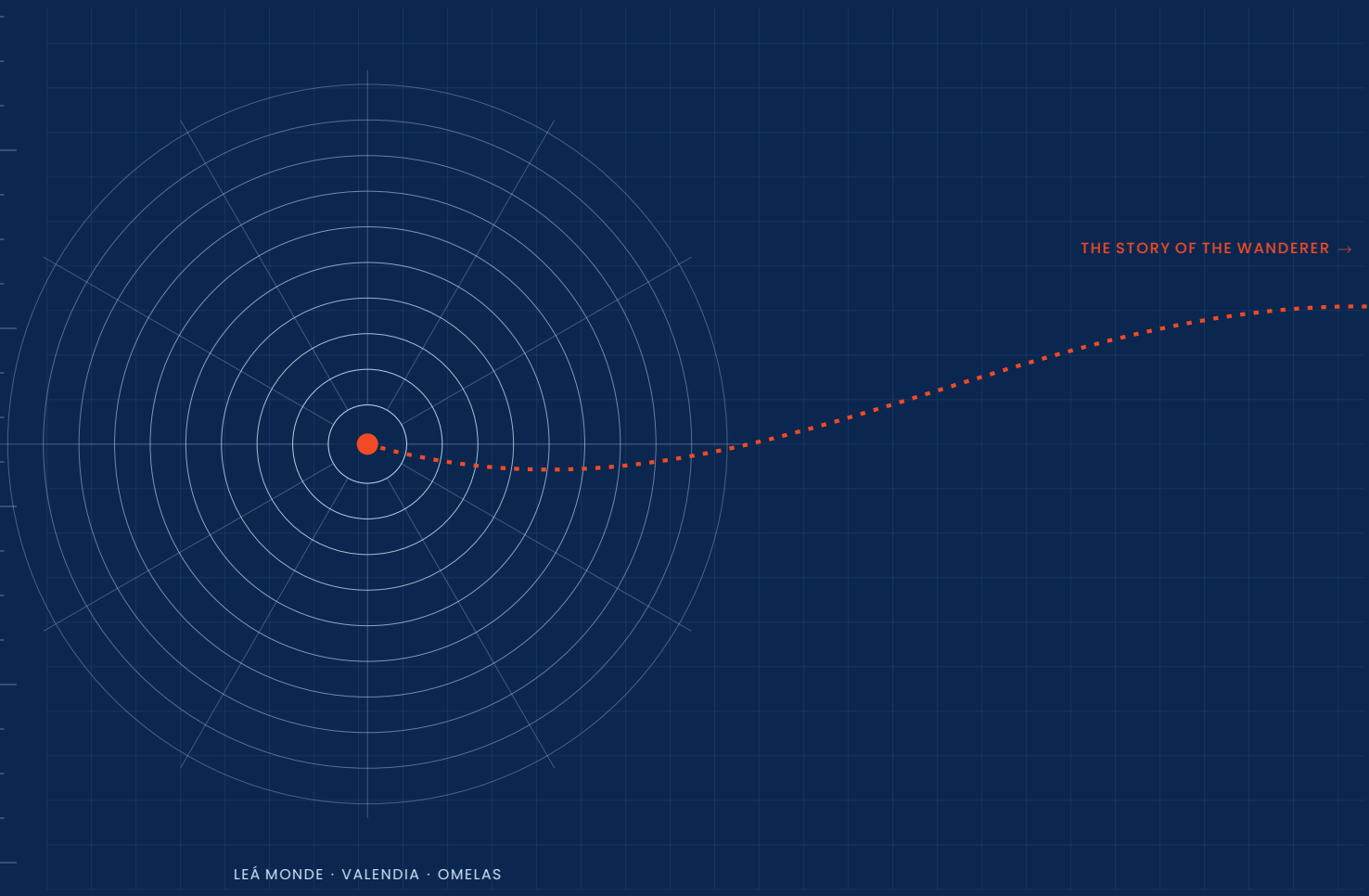
For the politics of memory. Tzvetan Todorov (1995) distinguished literal memory, which confines a traumatic past within itself, from exemplary memory, which draws from it a principle for present action; Ricoeur (2000) sought a just memory between excess and deficit. Stigmatophoric theory proposes a third mode: *custodial memory*, the bearing of a past whose truth cannot be established, as responsibility rather than as grievance or lesson. It is the mode appropriate to histories whose archives were destroyed or forged — and those are not rare.

For the study of games. The avatar is a stigmatophore by construction: a body whose past was written by designers, whose acts are performed by players, and whose back the player watches. Games that thematize this condition, as *Vagrant Story* does, can make the ontology of play into ethical content without ceasing to be games; their mechanics can carry arguments about inscription, memory, and responsibility that their narratives state.

For the study of speculative fiction. To the three familiar dispositions toward an implanted past — restoration, rejection, submission — the theory adds a fourth, assumption, and identifies *Vagrant Story* as its paradigmatic text.

VIII.8 The answer to the Riskbreaker's question

The Riskbreaker asked: if the past that made me was written by another, and if unwriting it does not yield a truer past, what in me remains mine? The answer is that nothing in the past remains his, and that this does not matter as much as the question assumed. What is his is the bearing. The mark is another's; the carrying is his own. *Fero, ergo sum.*



CONCLUSION

THE ONES WHO WALK AWAY FROM LEÁ MONDE

V

V · THE VAGABOND'S LETTER, BRANDED ON THE BREAST (1547)

- The child in the cellar
- Three departures
- The last face
- The story of the wanderer
- Closing

Vagrant Story ends where Ursula K. Le Guin's most famous parable ends — with a figure walking away from a city whose order rests on hidden suffering — but it changes the meaning of the departure. Le Guin's walkers leave the suffering behind. Matsuno's carries it.

The child in the cellar

In "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), a city of radiant happiness is revealed to depend, by some unexplained compact, on the perpetual misery of a single child kept in a filthy basement room. Every citizen learns of the child, and most, after anguish, accept the terms. A few, having seen the child, walk out of the city alone, and do not come back; the narrator cannot describe the place toward which they go, and doubts that it exists. Le Guin acknowledged the parable's source in William James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), which asks whether anyone could accept a world of general happiness purchased on condition that one lost soul, far off at the edge of things, lead a life of lonely torture.

Valendia is an Omelas whose basement is the past. Every order in the game rests on a hidden suffering that its beneficiaries have agreed not to see. The loyalty of the Riskbreaker rests on an innocent woman and child, killed in error by Ashley himself and converted into grief by the VKP. The authority of the Church of St. Iocus rests on the heretics it carved with an inverted cross. The power of Leá Monde rests on five thousand dead crushed in an earthquake whose author is never named; when Ashley asks who caused it, Sydney tells him to ask the sacrificed. The dynasty of the Blood-Sin rests, if the Ultimania is admitted, on a dying infant bound to his father's soul so that he might live and bear the key. And the game is haunted throughout by children: Marco, the son Ashley never had; Hardin's gravely ill younger brother, who died while Hardin sat in the prison his betrayal had not spared him; Sydney, saved at birth at the price of a bond that would kill him; and Joshua, the Duke's younger son, taken hostage in the prologue, when the cult of his elder brother, Sydney, seized their father's manor at Graylands, then taken into the city by Hardin, and last seen watching the city collapse beside Callo Merlose, his fate unknown. Joshua is the child in the cellar of *Vagrant Story*, and the game, like Le Guin's narrator, will not tell us what became of him.

Three departures

Three characters walk away from Leá Monde. John Hardin, who betrayed his comrades to the state for a promised freedom it withheld and then gave his loyalty to a cult whose purpose he doubted, escapes the city with the child he had come to love, and dies outside the walls of the wounds Guildenstern dealt him: he reaches the threshold of Omelas and no farther. Callo Merlose, the analyst of belief who became a reader of hearts, leaves the city with Joshua; her fate, like the boy's, is withheld. And Ashley Riot walks out of the collapsing city carrying Sydney Losstarot and bearing the key, and disappears from the record — except from the record that names him a murderer.

His departure is not Le Guin's. The ones who walk away from Omelas refuse the compact by withdrawing from its benefits; the child remains in the cellar, and their refusal changes nothing in it. Ashley does not leave the suffering behind. He carries its bearer out of the ruin and carries its instrument into exile. He is the one who walks away from the city carrying what the city had buried. The departure is not a refusal to look; it is a refusal to let the thing seen be used again. Where Le Guin's walkers take their conscience out of the city, Matsuno's takes the key.

The last face

In the game's final scene, Ashley evades capture by assuming the likeness of Callo Merlose. The choice of face is exact. Callo is the one character in the game who could read hearts, and the one who insisted that reading a heart does not certify its testimony; she is the one who, having seen into her captor's grief, answered it with tenderness rather than prosecution; she is the one who stayed with the child. The vagrant goes into the world wearing the face of compassion and of epistemic scruple — of the conscience that knows how little can be known and cares for others regardless. It is a disguise. It is also a vocation.

The story of the wanderer

The game announced itself as the prelude to the story of the wanderer, and that story was never told. The VKP's report, filed a week after the Graylands Incident, is the last word of the archive, and it is false: it names Ashley the Duke's murderer and records that he was never found. The only faithful record of the week is the memory card on which the player saved it. The polity's memory lies; the player's memory holds; and Ashley himself carries neither, only the mark. This is the final configuration of mnemonic sovereignty in *Vagrant Story*: the sovereign archive continues to decide the past, and decides it wrongly; the truth survives outside the polity, in the

private record of a witness who is not a citizen of it; and the self whose past is in dispute has left the jurisdiction of both, carrying a power that none of them will ever hold.

The statute of 1547 that Marx quoted ordered that the vagabond be branded with a V on the breast. The title of the game is that brand. *Vagrant Story* is the story of how a man becomes the bearer of a letter that marks him as outside every order that would employ him — and of how he makes that letter, as Hester Prynne made hers and the heretics of St. Iocus made theirs, the sign of something the brand did not intend. In the myth of Er, the soul of Odysseus, remembering its toils, chose the obscure life of a private man and then drank from the river of unheeding. Ashley chooses the obscure life without the river. He does not forget. He does not know. He bears.

Closing

The Riskbreaker's question — what remains mine when my past was written by another and its unwriting yields no truth — has received in these pages the answer that the game, more rigorously than any of its peers, compels. What remains is the bearing: the knowing, free assumption of an inscription one did not author, cannot read, and cannot verify, held in custody and not in use, carried out of the ruin and into a story no archive will write. It is a meagre inheritance, and it is the only one that no sovereign can forge.

Fero, ergo sum.

GLOSSARY OF COINED TERMS

The terms below are introduced by this dissertation; each entry gives the sense in which it is used and the chapter in which it is developed.

TERM	DEFINITION	DEVELOPED IN
Anamnesis without origin	An unmasking that removes a forged past without delivering a verifiable original, so that the counter-memory is no better warranted than the memory it replaces	II.7; VIII.2
Chiastic memory	A representation causally descended from an event in which the subject participated, which preserves the event's patient-structure while inverting its agentive structure, so that the agent remembers himself as the bereaved; functional when the inversion serves the party that performed it	II.4
Counter-chiasmus	The transvaluation by which the bearers of a penal mark convert a wound into a key, disclosing capacity beneath suffering; the inverse of the state's conversion of deed into wound	V.10
Custodial inoperativity	The bearing of a power without its exercise, which withdraws the power from every sovereignty that would use it	V.11; VIII.5
Custodial memory	The bearing of an unverifiable past as responsibility rather than as grievance or lesson; a third mode beside literal and exemplary memory	VIII.7
Deutero-canonical paratext	An official supplement (here the *Ultimania*) admitted to interpretation only when flagged, and never permitted to override the work's own withholding	Note on Method
Dorsal legibility	The condition in which the inscription that constitutes a self is legible to others and not to the self; figured by marks on the back and by the third-person camera	VI.8; VIII.2
Heterographic memory	A remembered past written by a hand other than the rememberer's, for purposes not his own	II.4
Hylomnesis	The retention and reenactment of the past by matter rather than by mind; the operation the game calls the Dark	IV.8
Implanter's position	The structural position of the player, who reads the avatar's back and directs its violence, and so resembles the institution that implants a past	VI.12
Mnemonic sovereignty	The power to decide on the past of others, prior to law because law presupposes facts: sovereign is he who decides on the past	V.1
Mnemopolitical triptych	*Tactics Ogre*, *Final Fantasy Tactics*, and *Vagrant Story*, read as successive relocations of an administered past from nation to church to soul	I
Spectral forgiveness	A release from the demand to settle an unverifiable past, offered by figures whose authority to forgive cannot be established, which leaves the debt borne	VIII.6
Stigmatophoric identity	Selfhood constituted by the free and knowing assumption of an inscription one did not author, cannot read, and cannot verify; *fero, ergo sum*	Introduction; VIII
Vagrancy (as political form)	Exit from the archive: the refusal of every institution that claims the right to write the past upon another's body	VIII.2; Conclusion

FERO, ERGO SUM

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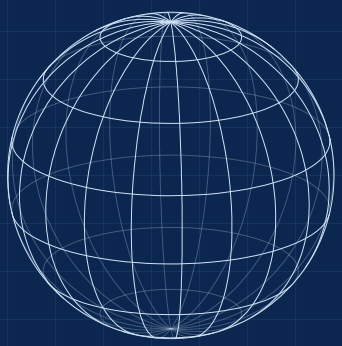
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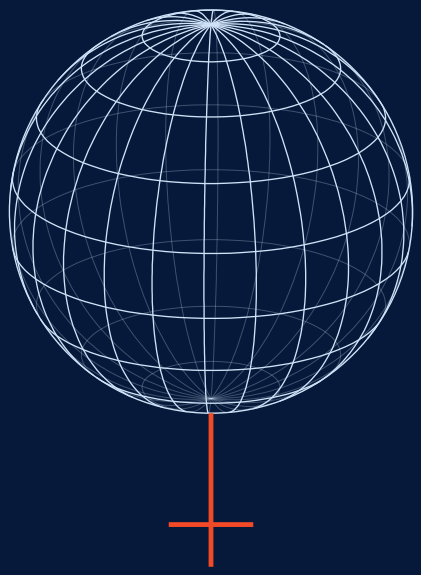
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KEYWORDS

Vagrant Story · Yasumi Matsuno · Ivalice · Square · Japanese role-playing games · game studies · philosophy of video games · procedural rhetoric · ludic form · personal identity · memory · false memory · implanted memory · **chiastic memory** · **heterographic memory** · **anamnesis without origin** · **hylomnesis** · art of memory · memory palace · Simonides · noble lie · Plato · Augustine · Locke · Parfit · Ricoeur · Nietzsche · mnemotechnics · Foucault · memoro-politics · **mnemonic sovereignty** · Carl Schmitt · Kantorowicz · Agamben · bare life · Walter Benjamin · ruin · allegory · Gnosticism · Hamlet · stigma · tattoo · inscription · Blood-Sin · **stigmatophoric identity** · **fero ergo sum** · **dorsal legibility** · **custodial inoperativity** · **spectral forgiveness** · **vagrancy** · Saint-Émilion · Borges · Philip K. Dick · Solaris · Memento · Metal Gear Solid · Planescape: Torment · speculative fiction

TERMS COINED IN THIS DISSERTATION





Fero, ergo sum.

I BEAR, THEREFORE I AM